ASH
and
SUN-CITRUS

A NOVEL

For whoever left, and for whoever kept
the light on.

A tree that is never cut back gives you all leaf and no fruit.

Farming saying, province of Marren

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Would You Still Choose the Orchard?

The Characters

PRATHEN OF THE ASHGUARD
The King's First Sword. Pulled alive from a burning village as a boy, he has spent twenty years paying that debt in scars. He is quiet and exact, and very hard to surprise.

BHELARA
Grows sun-citrus on a hillside terrace in the south. Stubborn and practical, with a sharp tongue and no patience for a crown that takes the province's sons and sends home a folded banner.

KING VALERIUS
The young king of Verrane, who pulled Prathen out of the fire when they were both boys. He is not cruel. He is lonely, and he has never found a way to say what Prathen means to him.

ODILE
Bhelara's mother. Small, white-braided and unimpressed by everyone. She shows love by putting food in front of people and daring them to refuse it.

GENERAL TORREN VASK
Commander of the Ninth Banner of the Northern Empire. He marches south because his own country is freezing, and nobody has offered him a better choice.

EDRIN WICK
Nineteen years old, the newest rider of the Ashguard, and the man the King trusts to carry a letter through a siege line.

Preface

This book is about a man who puts his sword down and a woman who never once asks him to pick it up again.

It is also about the king who lets him go, the general who comes south with an army, and the families on both sides of the border who learn about the war from lists of names. Each of them gets a past, because a person you know something about is harder to hate and harder to forget.

Most war stories are told from the saddle. This one spends a good deal of its time in a kitchen, on the terraces of an orchard, and in the gap between two letters. That is deliberate. A soldier who has never been shown what he is protecting can fight well for a while. He usually fights badly for the rest of his life.

Two stories sit behind this one, and it would be dishonest not to say so. *When Life Gives You Tangerines* showed how much of love is stubbornness and repetition: a bowl set down at the right moment, a wall mended without comment, a promise kept so many times it stops sounding like a promise. *Demon Slayer* showed what happens when a story stops in the middle of a fight to ask who the enemy used to be. Neither is retold here. The people, the country and the war belong to this book. The debt is to the way those two stories pay attention.

You may notice that the war has no villain. Terrible things happen in it, and some of them are done on purpose. But the people who do them are mostly frightened, and mostly following orders that turn out to be about food. That seemed truer than the alternative.

The title is two smells. Ash is what a house turns into. Sun-citrus is what a woman peels with her thumbnail when she has nothing else to give a frightened man. The story is about how far apart those two smells are, and how close they can end up.

PART ONE

The Citrus and the Steel

CHAPTER ONE

The Cup

The cupbearer's hands did not shake, and that was the first thing wrong with him.

Prathen noticed it the way he noticed most things, without deciding to. Three hundred guests, forty torches, the smoke of a whole roast boar hanging under the rafters of the great hall at Hallowfast, and every servant who came within ten paces of the high table walked like a man carrying eggs over ice. That was normal. You approached the King of Verrane and your hands remembered every coin you owed. This boy's hands were as steady as a mason's level.

He looked about seventeen. His livery was new and stiff at the collar. The old cupbearer had come down with a cough that morning and a nephew had turned up to take his place, and nobody had thought twice. It was the Midwinter Feast. Nobody thought twice about anything on Midwinter.

Prathen stood where he always stood, one pace behind the King's chair and a little to the left, where his sword arm had a clear line to anyone coming from the front. He was twenty-nine years old. He had stood in some version of that spot for fifteen of them.

King Valerius was telling the Chancellor something about grain tariffs and making it sound like a ghost story, which was a gift. He wore his gray kid gloves, as he did at every meal. They were thin and beautiful and made to measure, and he had stopped letting anyone mention them years ago.

"You're scowling at the pudding, Ash," he said, without turning his head.

"It looked at you wrong, Majesty."

"It's a pudding."

"They're the ones you have to watch."

The corner of the King's mouth moved. It was the only reward Prathen had ever wanted, and he took it, and then the cupbearer reached the foot of the dais with the silver tray and Prathen stopped thinking about puddings.

The boy was smiling. He had practiced it. The smile arrived a half-beat after his eyes had already measured the distance to the King's throat.

"Set that on the sideboard, lad," Prathen said. "I'll carry it up."

"It's the King's cup, ser."

"And I'm the King's sword. Set it down."

The boy did not set it down. He lifted the tray an inch, as though to offer it, and the cup went over and the wine ran red across the cloth, and from under the napkin came a short black blade that had been waiting there the whole time.

Prathen did not remember choosing to step. He remembered the knife, very close, going for the place just above the King's collar, and he remembered that there was a

gap between the knife and the King exactly as wide as his own body. Then the gap was full.

It did not feel like a stab. It felt like being punched under the ribs by a hand that had been left out in the snow. He caught the boy's wrist and snapped it, and drew with his other hand, and the sword went in before the boy had finished being surprised. That was all. A boy of seventeen sat down on the dais steps with a look of mild disappointment and did not get up.

Then the noise came back. Benches going over. Somebody screaming a long thin scream. The Ashguard closing in a ring, the King's chair lying on its back, and above all of it a voice shouting a name that took Prathen a moment to recognize as his own. Not *Ash*. The whole name. Nobody used the whole name.

"Don't," said Valerius. He was on his knees, and his hands were on the wound, gloves and all. The gray leather was going black. "Don't you dare."

"It's small," Prathen said. It seemed important to say so. He looked down. It was small, a thumb's width, and the skin around it had already turned the color of a bruise on its way to something worse.

"Bitter-thorn," someone said. "The blade's been oiled with it. Get Orwin."

"Valerius," Prathen said. He had not used that name aloud since they were boys. He saw the King hear it, and saw what it did to his face, and was sorry. "You'll ruin the gloves."

“I will have the gloves burned,” said the King, “and you will stay awake. That is an order.”

“I’m not the one bleeding on the carpet.”

“It’s a very good carpet.” His voice cracked on the last word. “Prathen. Stay.”

The ceiling of the great hall had forty years of soot on it. It went dark from the edges inward, slowly, like a lamp being turned down.

* * *

He was sick for nineteen days and properly awake for perhaps six of them. Orwin the physician came and went, smelling of vinegar and cloves, muttering to himself. The poison had burned something loose in the nerves of Prathen’s right arm. When he tried at last to lift a sword, the blade wobbled like a branch in wind and he had to set it down. His hand shook so badly that he could not hold a spoon. Orwin said it might settle and it might not. Warm air and quiet were the only medicines left, and the capital had neither.

On the twentieth evening the King came and sat on the end of the bed. He still had his gloves on. They were a new pair.

“There’s a province in the far south called Marren,” he said. “They grow citrus on terraces. It’s warm there all year, and the nearest army is eleven days away.”

“Who guards you?”

“Forty men.”

“Forty men aren’t me.”

“No.” Valerius looked at his hands. “They aren’t. That’s the point. I watched you take that knife and I will not watch it again. You’re going, Ash. It’s an order. It’s the first one I’ve ever given you for your own sake, so I’d be grateful if you didn’t treat it like the others.”

“And when I’m well?”

“We’ll see.”

Something crossed the King’s face, complicated and quick, and he got up and left the room before it could settle.

Prathen lay back and listened to the winter wind working at the shutters of the only house he had lived in since he was nine. It came to him slowly that this was the first time in twenty years anyone had told him to leave it.

CHAPTER TWO

Marren

It took eleven days to reach the south, and for most of them Prathen lay in the back of a covered wagon with straw prickling through his shirt and watched the world lose its color in reverse.

The gray went first. Hallowfast was slate roofs and wet stone under a sky like a pewter plate, and for three days the road kept that palette out of habit. Then the hills softened. The frost came off the ditches. On the sixth day a driver's boy pointed out a green shoot in a hedge and everyone in the wagon looked at it as though it had said something clever. By the ninth day Prathen could smell the sea. By the eleventh he could smell something else, sharp and sweet, with an edge like a blade drawn across a whetstone, and he did not know what it was.

"Oranges," said one of his two escorts, a rider named Hale who had been to the south once and spoke of it the way people speak of a bad inn. "Sun-citrus, they call it here. You'll get sick of the smell."

Prathen did not think he would.

Ten Wells was a village of whitewashed walls and flat roofs stacked up a slope above a bay so blue it looked painted. The headman, a harassed man named Gorm, read the royal writ twice with his lips moving, then a third time aloud to the escorts, as though it might have changed. It asked, in the King's own hand, that the bearer be given a bed, a roof and quiet for as long as his health required, at the crown's expense.

"The infirmary's full," Gorm said. "Marsh fever. Half the village has it." He chewed his mustache. "There's Windrow. Odile has two spare beds and no notion of when to refuse the crown."

Windrow turned out to be a hillside cut into steps. Stone walls held up each terrace, and on every terrace stood rows of low, dark-leaved trees, heavy with the last of the winter's fruit. After eleven days of gray, and a winter of worse, so much orange hit Prathen like a slap. For a moment he thought the fever had come back.

A woman stood on a ladder in the third row with a pruning hook in her hand, and she did not come down.

She was young, perhaps twenty-five, in a man's straw hat and a canvas apron gone dark with oil. Her forearms were brown and crossed with thin white scars. She looked at the wagon, then at the gray coat folded on the seat beside Prathen, and at the black flame stitched on its breast. Her face closed like a shutter.

"No," she said.

"Madam," said Gorm, "I haven't said anything yet."

“Not you. Him.” She pointed the hook. “He’s got a flame on his coat. That’s asking.”

“I haven’t asked for anything,” Prathen said from the wagon.

“You’re asking by sitting there.”

Gorm read the writ a fourth time, louder. She listened with her arms folded on the top rung of the ladder. “The crown has been in this house two ways,” she said when he finished. “It took my brother, and it takes a tenth of the harvest every year. It can keep its sick.”

“Bhelara.” A small old woman had come out of the house, wiping flour to the elbows. A white braid hung to her belt. She looked at Prathen the way a person looks at a sack of grain, judging weight. “He can have the loft over the press-house.”

“Mother.”

“It’s dry. The crown pays by the week.” Odile jerked her chin at her daughter’s boots, which were held together with twine. “He can’t sleep in the barn, he’ll die of damp, they’ll send another one, and we’ll have to feed that one too.”

Bhelara said nothing for the length of one slow breath. Prathen watched her do the arithmetic and hate it.

“The loft,” she said. “He eats at the end of the table. He doesn’t touch the trees.”

“Understood,” said Prathen.

“Don’t say it like that. Like I’ve given you an order.”

“How should I say it?”

“Say ‘all right.’ Like a person.”

“All right.”

“Better,” said Bhelara. “Slightly.” She turned her back and went up the ladder again.

* * *

The loft smelled of pressed rind, a bright, oily, bitter scent that had soaked into the beams over a hundred harvests. Prathen lay on a straw tick under a roof of clay tiles and listened for forty men.

There weren’t any. There were frogs. Beyond the frogs, a very long way off, the sea moved around in the dark like something turning over in its sleep. He had not been in a silent place since he was nine years old, and he found that silence had a texture. It pressed on the ears. His right hand lay on the blanket and trembled a little, as if it were still holding something, and he took it in his left and held it still.

Across the yard, through an open window, two women were arguing in low voices about whether he would last the week.

He gave it even odds himself.

CHAPTER THREE

The Factor's Toll

He had been at Windrow nine days and had not died, which was inconvenient, because Bhelara had already worked out the cost of the funeral.

She did not dislike him. That was the trouble. It would have been simple to dislike him. He was a king's man with a flame on his coat who had turned up on a wagon in the same year the crown asked every farm in Marren for two more sons. But he rose before dawn and washed his own shirt in the cistern. He ate what was put in front of him without remarking on it. And he did not look at the orchard the way soldiers looked at things. He looked at it like a man who had never seen anything left alone to grow.

On the tenth morning, Garrick Vole came up the cart road with four men and a mule.

Bhelara was on the threshing floor, tallying crates on a slate. She knew the sound of that mule. She had been listening to it since she was twelve.

"Miss Bhelara." The Factor had a face like a boiled ham and wore the green sash of the Citrus Guild as though it were a royal order. "A pleasure. I come on a delicate matter."

“You come on a mule. The delicate part is the mule.”

He chose not to hear that. “There’s a new levy. A war surcharge, collected on the crown’s behalf by the Guild. Four silver the crate, backdated to Midwinter.”

“Show me the writ.”

“The writ is being prepared.”

“Then I’ll pay when it’s been prepared.” She set down the slate. “I’ve seen a real one, Factor. My mother keeps it in the bread chest, folded in with my brother’s banner. It has a seal on it the size of my palm. Show me one with a seal like that and I’ll pay before you’ve finished the sentence.”

Vole tried another road. “You’ll want to ship to the coast this season. Roads cost money to keep. The Guild keeps the cart road, and so the toll…”

“The Guild doesn’t keep the cart road. My grandfather and eleven neighbors cut that road with their own hands, and the Ten Wells charter says it belongs to the commons. It’s in the press-house if you’d like it read to you. Slowly.”

One of his men, a wide fellow with a split ear, put a hand on her arm. “That’s enough mouth, girl.”

She lifted the sickle without any hurry. It had been her father’s, a curved thing gone red with rust, and she carried it for the thorn hedges. She laid the edge, very gently, against the back of the man’s wrist.

“Do you know what rust does in a cut?” she said. “Doesn’t matter how shallow. It goes bad. You lose the hand inside a week. I never clean it. I’d feel terrible if I had to use it.”

The man took his hand off her arm. Nobody moved. A wasp worried at the crates. Then Vole's eyes went past her shoulder, and his face changed from ham to something paler.

She didn't turn. She knew who it would be.

He was standing in the doorway of the press-house with one shoulder against the frame and the gray coat over his arm, the flame in plain view. He didn't say anything. His right hand was in his pocket. He looked bored and very tired, and somehow that was worse than anything he could have said.

"I was not aware," said Vole carefully, "that the Ashguard were lodged here."

"I'm a guest," Prathen said. "Guests don't interfere." He considered. "I was only watching."

It took Vole under a minute to collect his men, his mule and his dignity, in that order. At the bottom of the cart road he stopped to shout something about the long memory of the Guild, which the wind carried off.

Bhelara lowered the sickle. Her hand was not quite steady, and that made her angrier.

"I didn't need that."

"I know."

"Then why were you standing there?"

"I was told to keep out of the way." Prathen took his hand out of his pocket and looked at it as if it belonged to someone else. "I kept out of the way. I did it somewhere visible."

She wanted to be furious. She tried. But there was something in the way he said it, with no apology in it and no rescue either, that she had never heard before. People had

always decided she couldn't manage, or decided she shouldn't have to. Nobody had stood and watched her do it and simply let it be done.

"You didn't need me," he said. "So I didn't help. I'll admit I enjoyed it."

"Don't enjoy it. Work for your supper." She jerked the sickle toward the compost heap behind the barn. "That wants turning."

"My hand…"

"Shakes. Compost doesn't mind."

He looked at the fork, and at her, and went. He was bad at it. He was very bad at it, and he did not stop until the sun was behind the hill.

CHAPTER FOUR

Mud and Water

He was bad at everything, and that was what finally made her trust him.

Competence can be faked for a day. Incompetence can't. Over the next weeks Prathen of the Ashguard proved himself hopeless at an astonishing number of things. He pruned a young tree so hard it sulked for a month. He mixed the lime wash too thin, and it ran off the trunks like milk off a cat. He carried water in two buckets without a yoke because a yoke looked like giving in, and admitted at the end of the second day that he had never been so tired in his life.

He never made an excuse. He did the next thing badly, then did it again, a little less badly.

On the fourth terrace there was a dry-stone wall that had been sagging since the spring Ansel left. Prathen mended it at night, by lamplight, so she wouldn't see. She saw the next morning. He had used round stones where flat ones were needed, and the wall would have come down in the first hard rain. She said nothing. That night she went out with her own lamp and took it apart and rebuilt it stone by stone, and in the

morning he came out and looked at the wall for a long minute and said, “Teach me.”

“It isn’t teaching. It’s stones.”

“Then it won’t take long.”

It took most of the spring.

The rains came late that year, all at once. The sky went the color of a bruise at dusk, and by midnight it was falling so hard that the water on the upper terraces had nowhere to go. The main channel that carried it down the hill was blocked. A fallen stone, or a drowned goat, she didn’t know. She was out in her coat before she was properly awake, running with a lantern, and found him already there, waist-deep in brown water at the bottom of the cut, both arms around something she couldn’t see.

“A branch!” he shouted over the rain. “A big one! I can’t shift it!”

“Don’t shift it! Cut it!” She threw him the hook from her belt. He sawed. She looped a rope around the far end and hauled, and the two of them braced their heels in the mud and pulled until the branch let go all at once and went down the channel like a cork from a bottle. They both sat down hard in the wet. The water poured through. Below them, the lower terraces began to drain.

And Bhelara started laughing, and couldn’t stop. It took her a moment to notice that he was laughing too, a rusty, startled noise like a door that hadn’t been opened in years.

They sat in the mud under the downpour for a long time. When she finally looked up, a lamp was burning in the kitchen

window, and her mother stood behind it with her arms folded, watching, and was not even pretending otherwise.

* * *

In early summer she taught him to graft. It is the delicate job: a slit in the bark, a sliver of bud, a binding of waxed linen, and a pair of steady hands. His were not. He ruined nine in a row and swore at the tenth in a language she had never heard. She told him to use his left hand. He said he couldn't. She said he could try, and that the tree wasn't going to think any less of him. The eleventh took.

"That one's yours," she said, and tied a scrap of red wool around the branch so he could find it again.

He looked at it for a long time. "Nobody has ever given me a tree," he said, very quietly.

"It isn't a gift. It's a job. It wants watering."

He watered it every morning before she was up. She noticed because the bucket was always where she'd left it, and always wet. She also noticed that she had given him the good bowl at supper three nights running, the one without the chip, and she decided not to think about that at all.

CHAPTER FIVE

Smoke

They burned the prunings on the first dry evening of summer.

It was an ordinary chore. Every orchard in the south did it. The old wood and the clippings were stacked in a pit at the bottom of the lowest terrace and lit at dusk, when the wind dropped, and the whole village smelled of it for a night. Odile put the torch to the pile herself. Citrus wood burns sweet, with a heavy, oily smoke, and Prathen was coming down the path with an armful of brush when it reached him.

He remembered afterward that he had been thinking about nothing. Grafts. A joke Bhelara had made at dinner. He walked into the smoke the way you walk into a warm room, and the smell went into him like a key into a lock.

Then there was no orchard.

He was nine years old, and the roof was coming down.

It had started as a noise: a drumming, then a roar. The Northerners had come to Harrowmere at dusk, the last village before the Marches, and he did not know that yet. He knew only that his mother had pulled him out of bed and was pushing him toward the back door saying *run to the Aldens', run, Pra, go*, and that the sky behind the window was the

wrong color. His father was away on the watch. Something enormous struck the front door.

He didn't run. He turned back, because his mother had turned back, and a beam fell.

He didn't remember it falling. He remembered afterward: lying face-down on a floor that was getting hot, both legs trapped under a roof timber as thick as a man, and across the room, near the door, his mother. She wasn't moving. And there was a smell. He would know that smell for the rest of his life. Wood and hair, and something sweeter and worse underneath that he was too young to name and old enough to understand. He called for her. She didn't answer. He called for anyone. The fire made a sound like a huge animal breathing, and under it, from the village, came other sounds, which stopped one by one.

No one was coming.

He understood that very clearly. It was a plain fact, like the weight on his legs. Everyone who would have come was already gone or already here. He lay with his cheek on the hot boards and thought, with perfect calm, *so this is how it goes*.

Then something blocked the light.

A boy's shape, in the doorway, against the fire. Taller than Prathen, in a ruined silk cloak. A boy who had no business there, who had been riding the border with his father's autumn progress and had been separated from his escort, and who had seen a house burning and, instead of running the other way, had run toward it.

"I've got you," the boy shouted. "I've got you, don't move."

He took hold of the beam. It was ember-hot. Prathen heard the skin go. He would go on hearing it for twenty years. The boy did not let go. He screamed, and hauled, and said *I've got you, I've got you* over and over as though the words were a rope, and the beam shifted an inch, and then another. Then Prathen was out, dragged by the collar across floorboards that were coming apart, into a night that tasted of smoke and rain.

They lay in the mud of the yard, the two of them. The boy was holding his hands out in front of him like something he had been handed to carry. They were black and wet in the firelight. He stared at them with an expression of enormous surprise.

"I'm Valerius," he said. His voice shook. "You're going to be all right."

* * *

Prathen came back to himself on his knees in the dirt, hands pressed over his ears, with no breath in him at all. The pit was still burning. Somebody was kneeling in front of him. He couldn't stop shaking, and not only in his right hand.

"Leave him," Odile was saying somewhere, sharply. "Bhelara. Leave him be, it'll pass."

"It isn't passing," Bhelara said.

She did not say *what's wrong*. She did not say *it's all right*. She sat down in the dirt in front of him, close enough to touch, and reached into the pocket sewn on the front of her apron and took out a sun-citrus.

She dug her thumbnail into the skin. The peel broke with a small wet sound, and the oil sprayed in a fine bright mist, and the smell of it came across the space between them, sharp and cold and clean. It cut through the smoke like a knife through cloth. She pulled the peel away in one long piece, split the fruit, and put a segment into his mouth without asking.

"Chew," she said.

He chewed. It was sour. It was so sour his eyes watered and his jaw ached, and then, underneath the sourness, came the sweetness, slowly, from a long way down.

"What does it taste like?" said Bhelara.

"Sour." His voice was a thread. "And then… sweet."

"Sour first," she said. "Sweet after. It always goes in that order." She put another segment in his hand and closed his fingers around it. "Sit till it passes. I'll finish the fire."

She got up. She did not look back. She went down to the pit and took hold of the far end of the pile, and she dragged the burning brush around, a little at a time, until the wind was carrying the smoke away from where he sat. The motion looked casual. It wasn't. He saw it, and he knew she meant him to see it.

He thought about the King's hands, which he had never once been able to look at directly, and about the long debt he had been paying since the night they were made. In twenty years, everyone who had learned about the weight had either pitied him or hurried him past it. She hadn't tried to fix anything. She had sat down in the dirt beside the worst of it, and then gone to move the wind.

He ate the second segment slowly. It was sour first.

PART TWO

Laying Down the Sword

CHAPTER SIX

Steady

Autumn came in with the rains, and on the first cold night Odile announced that the loft was no place for a man in winter.

"He'll take Ansel's bed," she said, ladling stew. She did not look at her daughter while she said it, which was how Bhelara knew it had been rehearsed.

Bhelara put down her spoon. The kitchen went very quiet. Across the table Prathen had gone still in the particular way he had, like a deer that has heard a twig.

"Fine," said Bhelara.

That was all. Odile nodded and went on ladling. But later, with the house dark, Bhelara lay awake listening to a man's careful footsteps in her brother's room and found that she didn't hate the sound. She went down to the kitchen. A candle was burning. He was sitting at the table with his hands flat in front of him, as though waiting to be told what to do with them.

"Couldn't sleep," he said. "I keep thinking someone should be standing watch."

"Nobody's coming." She opened the bread chest, lifted out the loaves, and took what lay folded underneath. "You ought to know whose bed you're in."

It was a square of dark red wool, folded small and sharp at the corners, the way the crown folded them. She laid it on the table between them.

"Ansel was nineteen. He wanted to see the capital. I told him not to be stupid and to stay home and pick fruit. He wrote four letters. The first said *Cold. Food bad. Home soon.* The last one said *Save me the good bowl.*" She smiled, and there was nothing in it. "I always gave him the chipped one, to tease him. The good one has sat on that shelf for three years. Then in the spring I started giving it to you, and I didn't know why until just now."

Prathen said nothing. She was grateful.

"A note came with the banner. Three words. *He died well.* What does that mean? He was nineteen. He was cold and he wanted a bowl. What has *well* got to do with it?"

"I've signed a thousand of those," Prathen said.

Her head came up.

"The notes. The Ashguard writes to the families. I wrote that one to other mothers, in those words, because there's a form, and because after the first hundred I couldn't find any other words that weren't a lie."

"It is a lie."

"No." He looked at the banner. "It's the one true thing we could think of. It doesn't mean it didn't hurt. It means he was frightened and did it anyway."

“He’d have run,” said Bhelara. “Ansel. If there’d been anywhere to run.”

“Then he was frightened and he stayed.” He said it gently. “I would have liked to meet him.”

She didn’t cry. She folded the banner along its old creases, with great care, and put it back under the bread. “Thank you for not saying you’re sorry.”

“I’ve said it a thousand times. It has never once been enough.”

“No,” she agreed. “But it’s nice to be spared it.”

* * *

The harvest came in the new year, and the whole village came to pick, as they went to each orchard in turn. For three weeks Windrow rang with ladders and children and the thump of fruit going into baskets. Prathen worked the top rows beside Old Hesk, who had one arm and a great many opinions about the army. By the end of it his hand had stopped shaking. Neither of them mentioned it. She only noticed because she saw him thread a needle for Odile without being asked.

On the last morning she came out before dawn and found him at the edge of the highest terrace with his sword drawn.

She hadn’t seen it out of its sheath in a year. The sky was going from gray to pale gold, and the blade took the light along its whole length without a tremor, perfectly still, as though it had been set into the air. He held it the way a man holds a letter he does not want to open.

She watched him a long time from the ladder. Then he put it away. He did it carefully, like closing a book.

"It's steady," she said at breakfast.

"Yes."

"So you'll go."

"I haven't said so."

"You will. You're the kind who has to say goodbye properly." She pushed the bread toward him. "I'd think less of you if you didn't."

He turned his cup in both hands. His fingers were stained orange to the second knuckle. "I'd like to see the next harvest," he said.

It was not a declaration. It was nothing like a declaration. But in a year she had never heard him ask for anything, and she heard what it cost him.

"Then see it," said Bhelara. "There's a wall on the fifth terrace wants mending before then."

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Gate

The Southern Gate of Hallowfast was where he had left in a covered wagon fourteen months before, and it was where Prathen got down from the borrowed mare and began to take off his armor.

He had thought about leaving it at Windrow. It had spent a year in a chest under his bed, going slowly brown at the joints, and nobody there had ever asked what it was. But it was the thing he had come to put down, and a man can't put down what he has left behind. So it had come north on the mare's back in a sack that clanked at every step for nine days. Bhelara's idea of a farewell had been to hand him a loaf and a sun-citrus wrapped in cloth, say *Don't send a banner*, and turn around.

He laid the pieces out one at a time on the cobbles by the gate. Breastplate. Backplate. Pauldrons, left and right. Greaves. The gauntlets, which had never quite fit since the poison. Each made a small dull sound against the stone. The traffic going in and out stepped around him with the incurious speed of people who see a lunatic every day.

"Ser?"

The gate sergeant was an old soldier named Brask, as wide as a doorway, with a gray mustache and a face that had been rained on for forty years. Prathen had known him since the first day he wore the gray coat. Brask looked at the armor, and then at the farmer's coat, and Prathen watched him understand all of it in the time it takes to blink.

"Not 'ser,'" Prathen said. "Not today."

"Where do I send it, then?"

"Nowhere. Keep it."

"Here?"

"In the gatehouse. Out of the weather."

"I'll oil it."

"There's no need."

"Once a month," said Brask. He wasn't looking at Prathen. He was looking at a point on the gatehouse wall. "If it's all the same to you."

It was not the kind of thing you argued with. Prathen nodded once and walked in through the gate in a farmer's coat, and nobody looked at him at all.

He had not realized how much of an Ashguard's life was being looked at. The city went by him gray and loud, smelling of coal smoke and wet slate. A boy was selling hot chestnuts. A woman was shouting at a mule. No one stopped. No one stepped aside. He was just a man with orchard dirt under his fingernails and a stiff right shoulder, going uphill. It was the loneliest thing he had ever felt, and also the lightest.

The guards at the palace door knew him at once, and their faces went through three expressions. "Ser Prathen?"

"Just Prathen."

"His Majesty is at petitions."

"I know. I'll wait."

He didn't have to. A page ran ahead, and by the time Prathen reached the great doors the whole court had turned toward them like a field of wheat in wind. He walked the length of the hall. He had walked it a thousand times and never once alone. The tiles were the same, the long gray light was the same, and at the far end, on the dais, sat the King in a dark coat and gloves, his face so still that anyone who didn't know him would have called it calm.

Prathen knelt at the foot of the steps. He unbuckled his sword belt and laid the sword flat on the lowest stair, and the sound it made was very loud.

"Majesty," he said. "I ask for my release."

Someone gasped. Chancellor Orme took a step forward with his mouth open, and the King lifted one finger from the arm of the throne, and Orme stopped.

For a long time Valerius said nothing. His gloved hands lay on the arms of the throne. They didn't move, and the not moving frightened Prathen, because he had spent twenty years learning to read those hands, and for the first time he could not tell what they were going to do.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The King's Hands

Valerius had known for fourteen months that this day was coming, and he had spent every one of them pretending otherwise.

He sat with his hands on the arms of the throne, perfectly still, because stillness was the only thing he could be sure of. The court had gone silent behind him. Somewhere to his left, Orme was drawing the breath of a man about to be useful.

I could refuse, he thought. It was very clear. *I'm the King. It's one word.*

"Clear the hall," he said.

They went, with the shuffling reluctance of people who knew they were missing the best part. Orme went last and looked back from the door. The doors boomed shut. Then there was only the long gray room and the man in the farmer's coat, still kneeling at the foot of the dais with his sword on the step beside him.

Valerius knew that sword. He had put it into the hand of a fourteen-year-old with a bandaged chin, in this room, eleven days after a funeral.

He came down the steps slowly. The memory came with him, whole, as it always did.

He was sixteen, at his father's right hand in the council hall, bored, picking at a thread on his sleeve. Lord Hathorne had risen to make a point about tariffs and went on making it with one hand while the other came out of his sleeve. The knife was short and quick. His father said *oh*, in the voice of a man who has dropped a spoon. Then there was blood across the map of the southern provinces, and a room full of men who had stopped being his father's lords and become something else, wolves in velvet, all turning to look at him.

He was sixteen. He couldn't move.

And a boy walked out from the corner where the squires waited, with a wooden practice sword and a bandage on one hand, and stood in the way. Fourteen years old. All knees and elbows. "Back," the boy said, and his voice cracked in the middle of the word. A man laughed. Then the same man took a step, and the boy hit him across the knee with the wooden blade so hard that the crack of it carried to the rafters.

It bought forty seconds. Forty seconds was how long it took the captain of the Ashguard to reach the doors. The boy took a knife across the chin for them. The scar was still there. He had slept across the threshold of Valerius's room for the next six months like a dog, and Valerius had never found the words to ask him to stop, or to say what it meant, because every word he could think of was too small.

That was what nobody told you about a debt like that. It didn't get paid. It got larger and quieter, and one morning you

realized you had been leaning on it so long you'd forgotten you could stand.

He stopped in front of Prathen. The man in the farmer's coat had orchard dirt in the creases of his knuckles. His right hand rested on his knee, perfectly still.

In twenty years Prathen had never asked him for anything. Not a day's leave. Not a better post. Not a second helping at a feast. He had asked for nothing, and so Valerius had given him nothing, because it had never occurred to either of them that anything was wanted. And now here he was on his knees, asking for the single thing Valerius could not give without being emptied.

That was the trap in it, Valerius thought. Not the oath. The not-asking. How did you refuse a man who had never once asked?

"Say it again," he said. "So I know I heard."

"I want to go home, Valerius."

Valerius. The second time in his life.

"Home." His own voice sounded strange to him. "And where is that?"

"There's an orchard. A woman. A wall on the fifth terrace that needs mending." Something moved at the corner of Prathen's mouth. "It's a good wall."

A sound came out of the King that might have been a laugh. "A wall."

"It's a very good wall."

"Does she make you happy?"

Prathen didn't answer at once. He was a man who gave questions their full weight. "She makes me tired," he said. "She argues about everything. When she hands me a bowl, it's the good one." He looked up. "Yes."

Valerius closed his eyes for a moment. When he opened them, the choice had already been made somewhere below the level where he could argue with it.

"Stand up."

Prathen stood. He was a little taller than Valerius and always had been. From an inner pocket of the coat he took a small enamel flame, gray and black, the badge of the First Sword. It had traveled with him all year, Valerius understood. He laid it in the King's gloved palm. It weighed almost nothing.

"By my hand, and in my father's name," Valerius said, and the formal words came easily, because he had rehearsed them in the dark for fourteen months, "I release Prathen of the Ashguard from the office of First Sword and from the service of the crown, and I thank him for both."

"Majesty."

"I'm not finished. I command you to be happy."

"That isn't something a man can be ordered to do."

"Then do it badly. But do it. I'll be checking."

Prathen almost smiled. Valerius turned the badge over in his fingers, and when he spoke again it was quieter.

"There's one thing I can't undo. I can take the rank. I can't take the oath. The Ashguard answer the Horn, and the Horn

Law is older than my family. If it ever sounds for the realm, every man who ever swore is bound."

"I know."

"It hasn't sounded in a hundred and ten years. And I swear to you, on my father's grave, that I will never sound it for you."

"Don't swear things you can't keep, Valerius."

"I rarely do."

"If it sounds," said Prathen, "I'll come."

"I know," said the King. "That's why I won't sound it."

They stood there a moment without touching, which was how they had always done it. Then Prathen bowed, not very deeply, the way one bows to a friend, and walked back down the long gray hall. The doors opened for him. They closed.

Valerius stood alone in the quiet. Then he took off his gloves, one finger at a time, and looked at his hands.

They were not as terrible as people imagined. The skin was shiny and drawn tight and the color of old candle wax, and the fingers did not close all the way. They did not hurt. He had expected them to, as though some part of him had decided this was the occasion. They felt exactly as they always did. It was the rest of him that had changed.

The sword was still lying on the step. A servant came in to take it away, and Valerius said, "Leave it." It lay there three days. On the fourth he wrapped it in oilcloth himself, because he couldn't bear to see it rust, and had it carried up to his study, where he did not look at it either.

CHAPTER NINE

The Rain Wedding

She was not counting the days. She had simply, as a matter of housekeeping, noticed that there had been nineteen of them.

"You're wearing a groove in my terrace," said Odile from the doorway.

"I'm checking the wall."

"You've checked that wall nine times."

"It's a wall that wants checking."

It was raining the afternoon he came back. She saw the horse first, a small brown mare plodding up the cart road with its head down, and on it a man hunched in a coat the color of mud. He was soaked to the skin. He slid off at the gate and stood in the yard, dripping, and looked up at her on the wall.

"You're late," said Bhelara.

"I wasn't given a day."

"It's been nineteen."

"You counted."

"Someone had to. You're costing me labor." She came down off the wall. Her legs were not entirely reliable, which she blamed on the rain. "Well?"

"I've been released."

“Say it plainly.”

He took a breath. He looked about nineteen years old, standing there, and also about a hundred. “I’m nobody’s sword. I’ve got no rank, a bad hand, and I’m hopeless at most of what you’d want. I came to ask if I could stay.” He stopped. “I’m asking.”

“I don’t command,” said Bhelara. “I assign. And there’s a wall on the fifth terrace wants mending.”

He began to laugh. She didn’t hide her face this time. She took two fistfuls of his wet coat and pulled him down and kissed him in front of the yard, the mare, and Odile, who had just come out of the kitchen and said, to nobody, “About time,” and went back in.

Later, in the kitchen, with his coat steaming on the chair, she said into her cup, “He’ll call you back, if it comes to it. You know that.”

“He won’t call. He swore.”

“Men swear.”

“He doesn’t.”

“Then he’s a better man than most.”

“He’s the best I know,” said Prathen, and Bhelara decided to leave it there. There was a wedding to plan.

* * *

They were married a fortnight later, in the rains, because nobody in the south waits for good weather. Rain on a wedding is money.

Half of Ten Wells came. Gorm the headman wept and denied it. The Tolliver twins, thirteen and unbearable, carried the ribbon and fought over it. Old Hesk held a sheet of oilcloth over the registrar's head and swore at the sky with his one free hand. Odile did the binding herself, which is how it is done in Marren: the eldest woman of the bride's house winds a length of grafting linen, pale yellow and waxed, around the joined wrists of the couple. It is what you use to make two separate things grow as one.

Bhelara said her vow fast, like reading an invoice. "I'll argue with you every day and I'll feed you every night."

Prathen took longer. "I can't promise I'll never leave this house," he said. "I can promise that every day I'm away, I'll be trying to get back to it."

People nodded. It seemed a fair deal. Only Odile, who had buried a husband and sent off a son, looked at the rain for a moment as though it had said something rude.

At the supper, under the press-house roof, with the whole village shouting and the fiddle going, Bhelara set the good bowl in front of him, as she always did. He took it from in front of him and put it in front of her instead, and took her chipped one for himself.

"That's Ansel's bowl," she said.

"He asked you to save it," Prathen said. "I don't think he'd mind who for."

She looked at it for a while. Then she ate out of it. It was the first time in three years.

CHAPTER TEN

Three Springs

The first letter from the King came six weeks after the wedding. It was brought by a courier who looked appalled by the road, and it was addressed, in a hand like a row of fence posts, to *Madam Bhelara of Windrow*.

> *Madam. I am told I owe you a great deal and find I cannot say what. I enclose a purse and no explanation. Does the blossom come before the leaf, or after? V.*

Prathen answered it with three pages. Bhelara read over his shoulder as he wrote.

"Three pages on blossom."

"He asked."

"He asked politely. You could have said 'both.'"

"It isn't both. The first flush comes before the new leaf, but the second…"

"Prathen."

He kept going. Before he could seal it, she took the pen and wrote a line beneath his signature: *P. eats like a horse and sleeps like a stone. I am keeping him. B.* Then she packed

a crate of fruit to go with it, over his objections that it was a very long way, because a man shouldn't be eating porridge in a stone box.

The answer was four lines.

Madam. The fruit arrived. I ate nine at one sitting. The Chancellor says it is undignified in a king. I have asked for more. Keep him. V.

She read it three times. "That isn't about fruit," she said.

"No," said Prathen. "It never is, with him."

That was the pattern for three springs. A letter at the thaw, a letter at harvest, and always, at the bottom, a question about citrus, as though the King of Verrane had decided to take an interest in agriculture out of sheer determination. Does the fruit fall, or must it be cut. Why are the hedges thorned. Do the trees mind being moved. Prathen answered each in detail. Bhelara added a line. By the second year the added lines had become a conversation of their own, one that didn't include him.

Majesty: you have asked twice about the thorns. Come and be scratched by them and see. B.

Madam: the invitation is noted with alarm. V.

The orchard grew. Prathen built a second water channel, and ran the press, and burned the first batch of Odile's marmalade, which she made him eat to the last spoonful. The village stopped calling him the king's man and began calling

him Master Pra, which he pretended to mind. His mother had called him that, once. He had not told anyone. Old Hesk taught him to whittle. The graft with the scrap of red wool flowered in its second year, a handful of white blossoms smelling like a held breath, and he stood under it for a long time doing nothing, which she had learned meant he was happy.

In the third spring, up a ladder in the third row, she said without looking down, "I'll need less of this ladder soon."

There was a very long silence. A grafting knife hit the dirt.

"What?" said Prathen.

"The ladder. I'll need less of it."

He was standing under her with his face turned up and the knife forgotten at his feet, wearing an expression she would have given the whole harvest to keep. That evening they planted a tree on the highest terrace, with the sun going down, the first they had ever grown from seed.

"For the baby," he said.

"It's a tree. It'll take eight years to fruit."

"Then it'll be ready when it's ready."

The King's letter that autumn was four lines long and did not ask about citrus. Bhelara read it twice.

"He didn't ask," she said.

"He's busy," said Prathen. But he folded it small and put it in the pocket over his heart, and she saw him look north for a moment, and then not.

She did not say what they were both thinking. There were crates to pack. The fruit was coming in early that year, heavy and sweet, and it seemed rude to look north.

PART THREE

The Call of the Horn

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Breach

The letter from Windrow arrived on the same morning as the first snow, which came a month early and went across the courtyard sideways, like something thrown.

Valerius read it standing at the study window, because he had learned that if he sat down with Bhelara's letters he read them too fast. A sun-citrus sat on the desk behind him, the last of the winter's crate, gone as hard as a stone. He kept it for the smell. If you held it close, it still smelled of somewhere else.

Majesty. Your last letter was four lines and did not ask about the fruit. I have decided to assume you were distracted and not that you have lost interest, because I would hate to have wasted three years of crates. The harvest is early and heavy. We picked the top terrace on Tuesday and the Tolliver twins ate eleven each and were sick on the press-house floor, which is how I know the crop is sweet. P. has been unbearable since spring. I am told he is "expectant," which is a shocking misuse of the word, as all he does is

stand about looking at my feet. The child is due before the rains. If it is a boy I shall have to listen to P. be proud for the rest of my life. Eat something that isn't porridge. B.

He read it twice. The second time he was smiling, the whole of it, which he had not done at a desk in a long time. A child. Prathen's child. He turned the idea over like a coin found in a coat. He had let the best man he knew walk out of the throne room for exactly this, and it was working. It seemed an almost unreasonable amount of good for one decision to have made.

"Majesty."

Orme stood in the doorway. He had not knocked. In nineteen years he had never once failed to knock. In his hand was a sheet of paper, and one corner of it was stiff and dark.

"Greywatch has not answered its beacon," the Chancellor said. "Neither has Aldern Fort. A rider came in at dawn with an arrow in his back. He lived long enough to say that the Marches were burning, and to say the word *Northern*, and then he did not."

He laid the paper on the desk between the letter and the dry orange.

For a moment Valerius did not move. Beyond the window the snow went on coming down, early and thick. From the next room came the small ordinary sounds of a palace waking up: a door, a cart, a servant laughing at something. On the desk lay three things side by side in one pool of gray light. A

letter that smelled of ink and citrus. A fruit gone hard as stone. A report with blood on it.

He folded the letter along its creases and put it inside his coat. He had meant to answer it that night, and he didn't. There was no night in the weeks that followed when it would have been right.

* * *

By the twenty-second day, Hallowfast was shut.

Valerius could have told you how it happened, down to the hour. He had read every report in the order it came, and they had risen in badness the way a river rises, so steadily that no single one was a surprise. The border forts of the Marches fell in eleven days. The field army under Marshal Haldane met the Northern Empire at Ravenspur and did not come back. They found the Marshal's horse two days later. On the fourth day they found his gauntlet. The Ninth Banner and the Fourth came down the valley of the Ware at the pace of a glacier, and on the twenty-second day the last of the refugee carts squeezed through the Southern Gate and the Chancellor, personally, put his shoulder to the bar.

What Valerius couldn't get past, in the long nights, was the baggage trains. The scouts described them in plain, puzzled voices: wagons, hundreds of them, and women walking beside the wagons, and children, and sacks of seed grain. The generals kept not saying what that meant. This was not a raiding army. It had come to move house.

“They’ll starve us out by midwinter,” said Orme. The two of them stood on the wall in the hour before dawn, looking down at the Northern fires. There were ten thousand of them, small and orange and scattered across the dark plain like stars seen from the bottom of a well. “Or they’ll storm us, if their general is in a hurry. Majesty, there is still the river. A boat could take you south by night. The court could follow. Marren is eleven days off, and…”

“And I would bring this to them.” Valerius’s hands ached with the cold. He kept them folded under his arms. “No.”

“Then you must call the Horn.”

He didn’t answer.

“The Ashguard are thirty-one men,” said Orme, who was not a cruel man, only a very exact one. “Nineteen of them are inside these walls. The Horn Law binds every sworn man in the realm. The best of them is farming oranges in Marren.”

“I swore.”

“You swore not to sound it for him. It isn’t for him. It’s for the realm.”

“It’s for him.” Valerius looked out at the little fires. “We both know whose ear it’s tuned to.”

Orme said nothing for a while. “Yes,” he admitted. “I’m sorry for that.”

That day the Northern engines reached the walls. By nightfall the outer ward was burning. On the dawn of the twenty-fourth day, when Valerius climbed the old watchtower to where a bronze horn hung that nobody had touched in a hundred and ten years, he found that it was not a hard choice

after all. It was only a heavy one. Nothing a man had sworn was worth the lives of the people sleeping under the roofs below. He knew exactly what the Horn would take out of an orchard in Marren. A letter in his coat had told him the child was due before the rains.

He gave the order himself. The first note cracked. The second came out whole. The third rolled out across the river and the Northern camp and the gray country beyond, low and long, and somewhere far to the south a horn on a ridge would take it up, and then another, and then another, all the way to the sea.

Then he went down and wrote the letter. He wrote it three times. The first was an order, and he burned it. The second was an apology that ran to two pages, and he burned that too. The third was five lines. He sealed it with the large seal, the red wax, the realm's own.

Edrin Wick was nineteen, the newest man the Ashguard had. He stood in the study with his helm in his hands, very straight, and Valerius gave him the letter and the long bundle in its oilcloth.

"The river gate," he said. "There's a fishing skiff. Wrap the oars. Go through their line by water, then take a horse, and don't stop. He's in Ten Wells, in Marren, at an orchard called Windrow. You'll know it by the smell."

"Majesty." Edrin's eyes dropped to the bundle. He knew what it was. Everyone in the Ashguard knew that sword. "What shall I tell him?"

Valerius opened his mouth. He thought of three things to say, and every one of them was too small.

"Nothing," he said. "The letter says it."

Edrin saluted, badly, and went down the stairs two at a time. Valerius stayed at the window, bare-handed in the cold, and listened to the last of the Horn die away across the plain, carrying a promise he had broken the way you break a bone: all at once, and with a noise.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Horn

It came at dusk, in the last week of the harvest, while she was sitting sideways at the supper table because there was no other way to sit.

She was eight months gone and heavy as a wet sack. Her feet had stopped being her own in the autumn. Odile was ladling stew, and Prathen was cutting bread, and the lamp was lit, and the whole kitchen smelled of onions and citrus rind. It was an ordinary evening. She would think about that later: how nothing had warned her.

Then the horn on the ridge above Ten Wells spoke.

It was an old iron thing in a stone tower, put there in her grandfather's day against pirates, and she had never heard it blown. Every child in the south knew the call anyway, as part of a counting game. One long note for fire. Two for raiders. Three for the realm.

It blew three.

The sound came down the hill like something poured. When it stopped, the silence was enormous. And then, very faint, from the next ridge along the coast, another horn took it up, and then another beyond that, the notes going away

along the shore one after another like lamps being lit down a long street.

Prathen was on his feet before the last one ended.

He did not push his chair back. It simply wasn't under him anymore. She watched him not decide. She understood that this was what twenty years of oath looked like when nobody was asking it of him: the body went first, and the man came after, apologizing.

"Sit down," said Bhelara.

He didn't seem to hear.

"Prathen. Sit."

He sat. It took him a moment. He put both hands flat on the table, as he had on the night he moved into the house, and she saw that the right one was trembling, slightly, for the first time in nearly three years.

"That's the Horn," he said.

"I know what it is."

"I have to…"

"You have to eat." Her voice came out steadier than she expected. "Odile. Give him his stew."

Odile gave him his stew. Her hand on the ladle was not entirely steady either.

He didn't go that night. He didn't go the next. That was what she could never quite explain to anyone afterward. A horn was not a letter, he told her on the second evening, standing in the yard with his back to her. The Horn said the realm was in danger. It did not say what was wanted of him. Until someone came, he hadn't been asked. And Bhelara, who

knew a man bargaining with himself when she saw one, said nothing at all and handed him a hoe.

So the days went by, ten of them. He mended a terrace wall. He pruned. He sat up in the kitchen at night with the lamp turned low, not packing, not sharpening anything, only sitting. Once she came down and found him with his left hand clamped around his right.

"He'll go," she told Odile at the washing trough, on the ninth day.

"Yes."

"I'll hate him for it."

"Yes." Odile wrung out a sheet with a savage twist. "And you'll feed him first."

On the tenth evening, as the light went out of the sky, a horse came up the cart road at a stagger, and did not stop at the gate.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Rider

The horse went down in the yard. Not gracefully. Its legs simply folded, and the rider went over its head and lay in the dust without moving, a gray coat black with blood across the left shoulder.

Bhelara got there second. Prathen was already on his knees with the boy's head in the crook of his arm. Odile came running with the lantern, bad hip and all.

"Look at me," Prathen was saying. "Edrin. Look at me."

The boy's eyes opened. He was perhaps nineteen, with a face made of freckles and exhaustion, and when he saw who was holding him his whole body tried to stand to attention while lying down.

"Ser," he said. "I'm to… I have a letter. And the other thing. Both, ser. Please."

"Don't talk."

"He said the sword first." The boy's hand scrabbled at the saddlebag. "And the letter after. He said you'd know why."

They carried him in and laid him on the kitchen table. Odile cut away the coat. A crossbow bolt had gone through the meat of the shoulder and out the back, a clean wound and

a filthy one, and she went at it with vinegar and a boiled needle, talking to him all the while in the voice she used on stubborn trees. The boy did not scream. He held a strip of leather in his teeth and watched Prathen unwrap the bundle.

It was a sword. Bhelara had seen it a hundred times, hanging on a nail in the bedroom, and once drawn at dawn, still as a held breath. It had been left on the floor of a throne room three years ago. She had not known where it went. Now it lay across the kitchen table in a nest of waxed cloth, freshly oiled, and it seemed to be looking at her.

"Whoever wrapped that," said Prathen, almost to himself, "did it with his own hands. That's his knot."

Then he broke the seal on the letter and read it and held it out to her without a word.

She read it standing by the stove. It took seconds. The hand was a row of fence posts.

> *Ash. Hallowfast is shut. I have nine hundred men and thin bread and the whole of the North at every gate. I swore I would never sound the Horn for you, and I have sounded it, and I know whose ear it is tuned to. I am not commanding you. I am asking. V.*

"He's asking," she said.

"Yes."

"He knows you can't say no to that."

"Yes."

"Then it isn't asking."

"It's the only way he could do it." His voice was quiet. "He's never asked me for anything either. He wouldn't know how. He'll have written it ten different ways and burned nine."

"I don't care." She heard herself. It was not a voice she knew. It was rising. "I don't care what he would have written. You were released! He took it off you himself, with his own mouth, in front of his whole court. He put you out of the thing."

"He took the rank. Not the oath."

"I don't care about the oath!" The bowls on the table jumped when her hand hit it. "You have given enough blood to the dirt! Twenty years of it! You had a hand that shook for a year, you have an orchard, you have a child coming in a month, and you'll walk out of that door and leave me a folded banner in the bread chest, and it'll say *he died well*, and I'll have to read it!"

"Bhelara."

"No. Don't say my name like that." She was crying and she hated it. "You said you'd try to get back. You didn't say you'd go."

Odile quietly took the boy by his good arm and helped him out, hopping, the leather still in his teeth. The kitchen door closed. The lamp hissed. They were alone with the sword on the table and the rain beginning on the roof.

"I can't," Prathen said.

"You can. You have two feet and a mouth. You can say no."

"I can't, and you know why."

“Tell me why.”

He looked at the letter in her hand. “Because he asked,” he said. “In twenty years he’s never asked.”

She laughed. It was an awful sound. “That is the stupidest reason I have ever heard in my life, and I’ve listened to the Factor.”

“I know.”

“Don’t you dare agree with me!”

“I won’t tell you I’ll come back,” he said. “I’d like to. I won’t lie to you about it.”

“Good. I’d never believe you.”

Her knees went. It was only a cramp, low and hard, the child shifting like a fist in a sack, but he was across the room before she could fall, and had her in his arms, and she felt his hand spread flat against her belly. The baby kicked against his palm, once, as if to make a point. He made a sound she had never heard from him, and she realized his face was wet.

“Don’t you dare cry,” Bhelara said into his coat. “I’m the one who’s allowed.”

They stood that way a long time in the kitchen, with the rain on the roof and the sword on the table between them like a third person who had not been invited.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Northern Fire

He didn't go to bed. Bhelara did, finally, with the stiff dignity of a woman who intends to cry where nobody can see, and he sat in the kitchen with the lamp turned down and the sword across his knees.

It was not drawn. He only held it, the way you hold something that has come home. Its weight was exactly as it had always been, and that was the terrible part.

Rain on the roof. The smell of oranges. In the next room Edrin was muttering in his sleep about a boat. Prathen sat with his trembling hand and tried to make himself think about the King, because the King was the reason, the King was what the Horn meant, the King had asked.

But it was not the King who came.

It was a man with a torch.

He had always remembered Harrowmere from the floor: the beam, the heat, the boy in the doorway. He had never let himself go back to the minute before. Now it came, sharp as new glass.

His mother, pushing him toward the back door. The front door bursting inward. A man ducking under the lintel, big, in

a fur-trimmed coat, frost still in his beard because the Marches were cold in autumn, with a pitch-soaked torch in one hand. He was not shouting. That was what Prathen had forgotten, and it came back now with terrible clarity. The man was not angry. He was tired, and efficient. He looked around the kitchen the way a tradesman looks at a job, and he saw the thatch, and he put the torch to it.

His mother had a kitchen knife. She went at him with it. He knocked her down with the back of his hand, almost casually, not even a blow, the way you would move a chair. She hit the hearthstone and did not get up. And the man looked at the boy standing in the back doorway, nine years old, a child, and shrugged, and went out to the next house.

It was the shrug. Prathen had heard the skin of the King's hands go, had carried that smell for twenty years, and had never once thought about the shrug. A man had looked at a family and a roof and a child and found them not worth the delay.

That was what the North had been to him, all his life.

He sat very still. And the thing he had been trying not to see since the Horn came up whole at last: the terraces under moonlight. The thorn hedges. The press-house with its clay tiles. The kitchen he was sitting in. A man ducking under this lintel with a torch, tired and efficient, looking at a woman with a sickle and a swollen belly, and a white-haired old woman with a ladle. Putting the torch to the thatch.

Citrus wood burns sweet. He knew exactly how it would smell.

If Hallowfast fell, the valley of the Ware would open like a door. After the valley, the coast road. After the coast road, Marren, and Ten Wells, and a hillside cut into steps. He could not stop that from here, in a kitchen, with a farmer's hands. He could only go and stand where it was coming from.

He understood then that he was not going north to obey a king, though he would have gone for that. He was going north to stand in a doorway. His mother had turned back at one. A boy in a ruined silk cloak had run toward one. All his life he had been the one lying on the floor behind them. There was only one thing to do with that, in the end, and it was to be the one in the doorway.

* * *

He left at dawn, in the rain.

Old Hesk had brought out the bay gelding he had kept for thirty years and never let anyone else ride. "Take him," Hesk said gruffly. "He knows about armies. Don't let him get killed. He's older than you in horse years." Gorm had found a second mount for Edrin, who sat in the saddle gray-faced and upright by sheer stubbornness, the bandaged shoulder stiff under his coat.

Odile stood at the door with a bundle of bread and sausage and a sack of feed. "Eat," she said. "And bring the boy back too."

"I will."

"Then I'll feed you all."

Bhelara was at the gate in her father's straw hat, with rain running off the brim. She had not spoken since the kitchen. She held a cloth bundle in both hands, and she held it out.

"That one's not for you." It was a sun-citrus wrapped in a square of clean linen, the biggest and deepest orange he had ever seen on any tree at Windrow. "Give it to the King. He's been eating our fruit for three years out of a crate. He ought to taste one that's been in the sun."

He stared at her.

"I'm still furious with him," she said. "I'm not a fool. He sent you a letter that said please." Her voice cracked on the last word, and she pushed through it like a woman pushing through a hedge. "Put it in your pocket. And eat the other one when you're hungry. Not before. Not after you're dead."

"Bhelara…"

She laid her palm flat on his chest, over the pocket where the King's letters lived. "Don't say it. Whatever it is. You say it when you walk back through that door, not before. You owe it to me. I'm keeping the debt."

He nodded. He could not have spoken if he had tried.

He mounted Hesk's bay and looked down at his wife standing in the gate, with their child under her heart and the whole wet south behind her, and thought that he had never in his life been so afraid, or so certain.

He rode up the cart road. At the bend he looked back once. She hadn't waved. She was standing exactly where he had left her, a small straight figure under a dripping hat, and as he

watched she turned and walked, not toward the house, but up the hill.

It was a mile later before he understood where she was going. The thorn hedge. She was going to walk the whole length of it and see where it needed closing.

PART FOUR

Two Battlefields

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Oiled Armor

The road north was ten days of the same picture.

Burned farmsteads, a chimney standing alone in a field of ash. Dead oxen in ditches. And streaming past in the other direction, south, the people, in carts and on foot, with feather beds tied to their backs and the look of people who had stopped being surprised. Nobody spoke. A woman carrying an empty birdcage held it like a child. Prathen rode through all of it on Hesk's bay with his hand shaking on the reins, and Edrin beside him, telling him in short flat sentences what he had seen: the river, the engines, the burning ward. By the sixth day Edrin had stopped talking.

They reached Corbel Ford at dusk on the tenth. The relief army was camped in a half-flooded meadow on the south bank, and it was the saddest sight Prathen had ever seen. Two thousand levies from the southern provinces, farm boys in leather caps with pikes cut from ash saplings, still wearing the faces they had worn at home. Four hundred cavalry on horses that were mostly bone. And twelve Ashguard, the ones who had been away from Hallowfast when it closed, standing at

the edge of the firelight in gray coats that were no longer very gray.

They saw him come in. He watched it go through the camp from man to man: a murmur, and then a quiet shifting, like cattle before weather. Someone said “First Sword.” Someone else said it again.

“I’m not,” Prathen said, to no one.

“You’re the only man here they’ll follow.” Commander Dray was lean and gray, fifty years old, the last general in the field, with red-rimmed eyes and a voice scraped smooth. He had been Haldane’s second at Ravenspur and had watched the rest of it from a hill. “I’ve got two thousand boys who’ve never held a spear in anger. They’ll follow a name. They’ll follow yours.”

“It’s a bad name.”

“It’s the only one I’ve got.”

At the edge of camp a wagon stood with an old man sitting on its tailboard, arms folded, as wide as a doorway, with a gray mustache. Prathen stopped walking.

“Sergeant.”

“Sir.” Brask got to his feet. He looked ten years older than he had in the spring. “The King’s orders were to keep everything that wasn’t nailed down, and some things that were. I took the liberty.” He pulled back the canvas. The armor lay in the wagon bed, every plate of it, black and bright, oiled to a gloss that caught the firelight. A strap had been replaced. A buckle polished. “Once a month, sir. I said I would.”

Prathen put one hand on the breastplate. It was warm from the sun that had been on the wagon all day. “It’s been three years, Brask.”

“Thirty-six times, sir. I kept count.” Brask cleared his throat. “Don’t thank me. You’ll make me think we’re losing.”

He put it on. Brask buckled the straps one by one, as he had done a hundred times, with thick fingers that moved quickly and not quite steadily, and neither of them spoke. The breastplate fit. The gauntlets did not; he left the right one off. He stood in the firelight in black steel and felt the oldest and strangest sensation, like putting on a skin he had shed and finding that it had waited for him.

Later, in Dray’s tent, over a map held down with two daggers and a mug, they planned.

The Northern line ringed Hallowfast on three sides, Dray said. The river guarded the fourth, and on the river side stood the River Gate, small and old and easy to forget. It was the thinnest part of their line, because the Northern general kept his best men at the main gate, where the engines were. If the vanguard hit the river side at dawn, and the King heard it, he would come out.

“He’ll hear it?”

“You can’t hit that line at dawn with two thousand men and be quiet about it. And he’s been waiting ten days for something. He’ll come.”

“Who commands them?”

“Torren Vask, Ninth Banner.” Dray rubbed his eyes. “He’s careful. Doesn’t waste men, and doesn’t burn what he doesn’t

have to. We've found granaries behind his lines that he left alone. I don't know what to make of that."

"What do you make of the baggage trains?"

Dray looked at him for a long moment. "That they're hungry," he said quietly. "That they're not here for us. They're here for the fields behind us." He was silent a moment. "We took a scout at the ford three days ago. Half dead, frostbitten to the knees. He had a strip of dried rind in his fist and wouldn't let go of it, not for the surgeon, not for soup. He kept asking, in what Verrane he had, whether it was true. Whether the south was warm. Whether the fruit grew there like small suns. Their Emperor has been telling them so since spring. That's what they were promised for coming."

"What did you tell him?"

"Nothing. I gave him soup. He died in the night." Dray folded the map. "He still had the rind in his hand when we buried him. It doesn't make them less dangerous. Hungry is the most dangerous thing there is."

Prathen thought of a man in a doorway with a torch, and a shrug. He tried to hold that picture next to a dead boy with a strip of rind in his fist, and the two would not sit together.

"Dawn," he said.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Vanguard

They went in at first light, in a mist that smelled of river and old smoke.

Prathen had two hundred men on foot behind him, picked from the levies and the Ashguard and the cavalry whose horses had died. Edrin stood on his left, bandaged and fierce. In front lay thirty yards of open mud, a ditch, a palisade of sharpened logs, and beyond it the Northern camp, still waking, with cookfires going and the smell of boiled barley drifting across the field. He stood in the mist with a sword in his right hand and thought: *it's steady*. It was always steady with a sword. That was the thing he had never told her. His hand shook for spoons and needles and doorknobs. It had never once shaken for this.

"On me," he said, and ran.

For the first minute there was only noise: two hundred men breathing, boots in mud, the first crossbow bolts hissing past, a shout in a language he did not know. They reached the ditch and went down into it and up the other side, and the palisade came apart under axes, and then he was through and

the Northern camp was all around him and everything stopped being a plan.

He did not afterward remember most of it. He remembered pieces, sharp and the wrong size. A man in a quilted coat with a pot of barley in his hands, standing in front of a tent, looking at Prathen with polite surprise, and Prathen's sword went through him before either of them understood what was happening. A boy from Marren, one of the levies, sixteen, in a cap too big for him, who ran beside him shouting the name of his village like a war cry, and then was not beside him anymore.

The shield wall. They hit it at a run, shoulder to shoulder, and it held, and the sound that came from it was the sound of a butcher's yard. He drove his blade through the gap between two shields and felt it bite and pulled it back wet. He took a blow on the pauldron that numbed his arm to the fingers. He killed a man who was crying. He killed a man who called for his mother in a language Prathen didn't know and didn't need to.

He had been very good at this once. He found that he still was, and he hated it with a clear cold hatred, and went on doing it.

It was the boots that stayed with him. The dead Northerners wore boots wrapped in rags, and under the rags the feet were swollen and split by frost. Their coats were patched. Their hands, when he stepped over them, were thin. They had come three hundred miles through autumn mud to

reach this field, and they had arrived starving, and they fought like men with nothing to go home to.

It made no difference. He killed them anyway. They stood between him and the gate.

By the time the sun was fully up, the vanguard had cut through. A hundred and forty of the two hundred were still on their feet. Edrin was beside him with blood down his face from a split brow, shouting with a wild exhilaration that Prathen recognized and did not envy.

Ahead lay the River Gate, a small arch of black stone, its doors shut, banners hanging from the wall above. Between the vanguard and the gate was a trampled space of mud and corpses and broken pikes. And across it, walking, quite unhurried, came a single man.

He was large and not young, perhaps forty-five, gray in the beard, in a plain steel breastplate and a cloak of white bearskin that looked less like decoration than clothing. He held a long straight sword in a hand that seemed to have forgotten it was holding anything. The men around him, hundreds of them, Northerners and Verrane alike, stopped fighting and stepped back and made a ring without being told, in the old way, the way men always did.

Prathen knew who it was. He had known since the mist.

"General Vask," he said.

The man stopped ten paces away, and the whole field went quiet around them, as though the war had paused to see how it would go.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Thorn and Water

For ten days after he rode out, Bhelara walked the hedge.

Everybody humored her. That was what she noticed afterward. Gorm came by with his hat in his hands and told her the crown would see to it and that in her condition she ought to rest. Old Hesk stood with his one arm folded and watched her measure gaps in the thorn. The Tolliver twins were told to dig pits under the mulch in the lanes, and did it with the dreadful solemnity of children who have been given a job to keep from being sent home. She let them humor her in turn. She did not have the breath to argue.

The thorn hedge ran the whole length of the orchard's lower side, six feet thick: bitter orange grown wild and trained close, with thorns as long as a finger and sharp enough to go through a boot. It was meant to keep out goats. Every farm in the south had one. She had never in her life thought of it as a wall.

Then on the tenth evening Tam Tolliver came tearing up the cart road at a dead run, shirt out, with no breath to say anything but a number.

“Thirty,” he gasped. “Riders. At the Marsh Ford. Coming along the coast road. Northern. I saw them.”

Nobody humored her after that.

They crowded into the press-house at dusk, everyone in Ten Wells who could still walk, which was not many: eleven men, thirty-odd women, a dozen boys, a baby here and there. No soldiers. The village had sent the last of its young men north in the spring, and the crown had not sent them back. Gorm was ashen. Widow Pell was crying and trying not to. And Bhelara stood at the head of the press with one hand on the great screw and the other under her belly and found it easier than she expected to talk, when you had already done your thinking with your feet.

“We can run,” she said. “To the caves below the point, or inland. They’re thirty riders, not an army. They’ll want food and horses and anything that burns. If we run, they have all of it.”

“And if we don’t?” said Gorm.

“Then we make Windrow cost more than it’s worth.”

She told them. The thorn hedge, closed with cut brush at every gap but one, the lower gate, so that the only way in was a lane a horse could walk down but not turn in. The pits the boys had dug under the leaf mulch in the lanes beyond, eleven of them, waist-deep. Goat bells strung on cord at the height of a horse’s chest along the second terrace, so that anything which broke the line would shout about it. And the upper sluice, which fed the whole terrace system: opened at the right

moment, it would send the water down the lanes in a sheet and turn the lower rows to a bog as thick as porridge.

"A horse in porridge," said Old Hesk slowly, "is a man on foot."

"And a man on foot in an orchard at night can't see six feet." She looked at him. "You know about armies."

"I know about getting killed in them." But his eyes had gone bright and hard, like an old dog hearing a word he knew. "I'll tell you what else gets killed in them. Plans. Anybody who's done this twice will see that one gap and not trust it. He'll go round."

"Round is thorn."

"Thorn can be cut, girl. It's only slower."

She had no answer to that. She put it with the other things she could do nothing about.

"The little ones to the caves," she said. "And anyone over sixty."

"I'm seventy-one," said Odile from the back, "and I'm not leaving my oven."

"Mother."

"Somebody has to feed them after." Odile folded her arms. "That's an argument you can't win, and I won't hear it."

It was, Bhelara thought, a good deal like talking to a tree.

By midnight they were in place. Word had gone out to the next villages along the coast, and by the small hours the farmers of three parishes had come up the cart road in twos and threes with hoes and billhooks and one ancient crossbow. The women stood on the terraces behind the walls with

sickles and pruning hooks and baskets of stones. The men held the press-house doors. The twins crouched at the sluice with the instruction to wait for the third bell and then pull on the bar with their whole weight. Bhelara sat on the wall of the second terrace in her father's hat, the sickle across her knees and the child heavy and still inside her, and looked north into the dark.

She had told him not to send a banner. She had not thought to tell herself not to need him.

It was a very stupid thing to think, with thirty riders coming. She put it away carefully, the way you put away something that will be wanted later, and listened for the bells.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The General's Winter

General Torren Vask of the Ninth Banner did not sleep the night before the River Gate, and he did not pretend to.

He sat in his tent on the plain before Hallowfast with a map he knew by heart and a cough he had stopped noticing, and listened to the camp. It sounded like any camp. Men muttering around the fires. A mule complaining. A child somewhere in the baggage lines crying thinly, until a woman's voice hushed it. He had forbidden anyone to remark on the children. It was the only order of the campaign nobody had needed to be told twice.

On the table beside the map lay a small tin. It had once held tea. It was dented at the corners and the paint was gone, and inside it were seven strips of dried peel, brown and curled and brittle, that smelled even now, two years on, of something he had no word for in the language of the north.

He knew where he had got them. That was the trouble. He could never stop knowing.

It had been the third winter of the frozen wells.

Skell, in the high north, had always been cold, but it had been cold in an orderly way, the kind of cold people plan for.

Then the winters changed. The first year the river froze early and the herring did not come. The second year the wells froze to the bottom, and men chopped through the ice with axes to find dark water that tasted of iron. By the third winter the barley had failed twice and the cellars stood empty and the people of Skell had begun to eat the seed grain, which was how you knew.

His daughter, Runa, was six. She had her mother's black hair and her father's habit of going very quiet when she was afraid. She had a cough that came and went. One night in the dark she asked, in a voice with no complaint in it, whether it was true that in the south there were fruits like little suns. A trader had said so to a boy at the market, and the boy had told her.

He did not know. He said he thought so.

She said she would like to smell one. Only smell. She wouldn't eat it, she said, if it was valuable.

The next day he sold his father's signet ring to a southern trader who had wandered up to Skell by mistake, and got in return a tin of dried peel the size of his fist. He carried it home through the snow under his coat like something alive. Runa held the first strip to her nose and shut her eyes for a long time. "It smells like warm," she whispered. That was all she said.

She died in February with a strip of the peel under her pillow. Ilsa, his wife, had not spoken a full sentence since.

That spring the Emperor sent for his generals. There is no more room in the north for the people we have, the Emperor

said. The south has fields that give three harvests. The south has fruit like small suns. Go and take it, or we will all be dead by the time the wells thaw. And the generals, who had all buried a child that winter or were afraid they would, said yes.

So there were wagons, and women walking beside the wagons, and children in the wagons, and seed grain, because anyone left behind in the north would not live to be fetched. He had known it wasn't conquest. It was a people walking out of a grave in boots wrapped in rags with a sword in front to clear the way. It was the worst thing he had ever done, and he could not think what else there was.

He had burned villages on the way. He did not remember most of their names. That was his own private horror, and he kept it where he kept the tin.

Outside, the first gray was coming. Faintly, from the river side, he heard shouting begin, and a horn. The river side had been thin because there were not enough men to make it thick. That was no secret. He had been losing them to the cough and the frost all autumn.

He could end this, he thought. If he took the capital he could hold the south, and he would be gentle with it. That was the only promise he knew how to keep.

He put the lid back on the tin and slid it into the breast of his coat, against the place where a man keeps his heart. He picked up his sword. Then he went out to meet whoever had come, with the white bear of the Ninth Banner snapping overhead and the sky the color of weak tea.

He saw the man at once: one man in black steel, standing in the mud with a sword held perfectly still.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The River Gate

"You're the First Sword," the General said. His Verrane was careful and accented, learned from books or captives.

"Not anymore."

"Then why are you here?"

Prathen thought about it. There were several answers. "A doorway," he said finally.

The General considered that, and seemed to understand it better than he should have. "I'm sorry for this," he said. "I want you to know."

"So am I."

It was not a fast fight, which surprised him. The General was patient and heavy-handed, a man who had learned his craft in frozen yards against bigger men, who made no flourishes and wasted no motion. Prathen was quicker. It made no difference. The General's guard did not open. They circled, and the blades rang, and around them the ring of men stood in the mud and did not breathe.

Then the General dropped a shoulder, and Prathen lunged, and the blade came across low and up in a slashing arc and opened his face from brow to cheekbone.

There was no pain at first. There was a bright white noise, and then the left side of the world went red and then went out. He staggered. Blood ran into his mouth, hot and salt. He understood, with the odd clarity of shock, that he had lost the eye. He brought his own blade up with a hand as steady as stone, and the General, who had expected him to fall, was one half-step too slow.

The sword went in below the breastplate, under the ribs, upward. It was the same place the cupbearer's knife had found him. He felt the blade meet the end of its travel. The General looked down at it with tired interest, and then up at Prathen, and Prathen saw that he was weeping himself, and did not know when he had started.

The General's knees folded. Prathen went down with him, because he was still holding the hilt, and they knelt in the mud face to face like men at prayer.

"Runa," the General said. It was not to Prathen. His eyes had gone somewhere past Prathen's shoulder. "I couldn't find a whole one. I'm sorry. I only found the peel."

Something slid from the breast of his coat and rolled in the mud: a small dented tin, and out of it a few brown curls of dried peel.

Prathen smelled it. Through the blood and the smoke and the river, it reached him: sharp, faint, old, unmistakable. And with it came a dead scout at Corbel Ford, a strip of rind in his fist, and a question nobody had answered.

He did not decide. His hand went into his coat and came out with the sun-citrus Bhelara had given him for the road.

He dug his thumbnail into the skin, as she had, and the oil sprayed in a fine bright mist between them, and the General's eyes came back into the world.

"What…"

"Sun-citrus," said Prathen. His voice was a ruin. "From the south. It's real. It's all true."

He pulled out a segment and put it to the dying man's lips. "Eat. It's sour first."

The General chewed. His face crumpled at the sourness, in a way so purely and childishly startled that Prathen's remaining eye filled and ran over. Then it smoothed. A look came into it that Prathen would see in his sleep for the rest of his life.

"Warm," said the General of the Ninth Banner. "She said it would be warm."

He was smiling when he died.

Prathen stayed on his knees in the mud with the man's weight against his shoulder and the empty rind in his hand, and he said it aloud, quietly, to a name he had learned a minute ago, to a child he would never see. "I'm sorry," he said. "I'm sorry, Runa. I'm so sorry."

Around him the ring of men had broken. Northerners stood with their hands loose at their sides, looking at their General. Someone had begun, in the Northern tongue, a low strange keening. And from behind them, from inside the walls, high and far and clear, came a sound he had not heard in three years and would have known in his grave: the horn of

Hallowfast, once, twice, three times, and under it the grinding crash of the River Gate coming open.

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Terraces Burn

They came in the last dark before dawn.

First the bells. A single bell, high and tinny, somewhere on the second terrace, and then the whole line of them jangling on their cords, and under the bells a noise she had never heard in her life and knew at once: horses, a great many, coming at a trot down a lane that was not meant for them.

"Third bell!" she shouted. "Now! Pull!"

Up the hill, two thirteen-year-olds threw themselves at a wooden bar with all the weight of their small bodies, and nothing happened.

She could hear them from where she sat. Grunting, then swearing in a way they certainly had not learned from her, then Tilly's voice going high and thin: "It's stuck! It won't go!" The autumn rains had swollen the frame, or a stone had worked its way into the track. She never found out which. The water that was meant to be pouring down the lanes in a sheet stayed exactly where it was, behind the gate, in the dark, being no use to anyone.

The first rank of riders came down the lane at a trot, and the lane was dry.

It was not nothing. The hedge took the ones who tried to turn, tearing horses' legs and men's faces on a thousand finger-long thorns. The pits, dug with great care by two children who were now weeping at a stuck gate, took four horses in the first minute. The bells screamed. But a rider whose horse has not gone into porridge is still a rider. The ones who got through the lower gate pushed on up the lane at a canter, and the rest dismounted and came after them on foot, wet only with sweat, quick and quiet and very good at this.

Bhelara sat on the wall of the second terrace with her sickle on her knee, because standing was no longer possible, and watched a man come toward her through the rows.

He was young. That was what she would remember. He was perhaps twenty, in a patched fur coat, gray with hunger, carrying a notched sword in a hand that shook. He saw her, a pregnant woman on a wall, and for a second his face did something that was almost relief. Then he saw the sickle, and his face went blank again, and he came on.

She did not decide. It went in like pruning a branch, and she would never forget how little it resisted. He looked surprised. He sat down in the leaves with both hands over the place and said a word in his own language, and then nothing.

She stared at the sickle. Then she was sick over the side of the wall, neatly and without a sound, and wiped her mouth on her sleeve, and looked up the hill.

The gate had not moved. Below her, on the second terrace and the first, the women were holding the walls, but they were

holding them against men who could see where they were going, and nothing was slowing those men down. She had planned for porridge. She had planned for thirty riders floundering in a bog while a village stood over them. Without the bog, thirty hard men were simply winning.

Three terraces up ran the main water channel, the one she and Prathen had sawed a branch out of on a night of rain. Its retaining wall was the old wall on the fifth terrace, the one that had needed mending since before the wedding. She knew exactly which stone held it. She had rebuilt that wall twice.

Nobody else knew which stone.

She got down off the wall. She was eight months gone and had not run since the summer. She ran. She went up the steps cut into the terrace walls with one hand on her belly and the other on the sickle, and on the last step she went up on her hands and knees, and a woman she had known all her life, fighting a man with a hoe, saw her go by and screamed her name.

The fifth terrace wall stood where she had left it, black and patient in the dark, holding back a whole hillside of rain. She found the red stone by touch. It had a notch in it where a mason's chisel had slipped in her grandfather's time. She jammed the hook behind it and sat down on the handle with the whole of her weight. For the first time in two months, being heavy was useful.

The stone came out. Nothing happened. Then the wall, which had never in its life been asked to do anything but stand, leaned, and let go.

The water came down like a thrown door. It took the fifth terrace and the fourth and went down the steps in a brown roar, and the lanes between the rows, dry a moment before, ran bank to bank. The riders still on horseback found themselves in a river. The men on foot went from wading to swimming to clinging to tree trunks, and the ones who had been winning were suddenly fighting just to stand. Below her the horses began, one by one, to scream.

She was still on her knees in the mud of the broken wall when she heard the axes.

They came from above, under the noise of the water: a steady, patient chopping. Not a rush. Not a panic. Somebody was cutting a hole. She looked up and saw the thorn hedge along the top of the hill begin to open, branch by branch, with torches waiting behind it. They had never meant to come up the lane at all. Somewhere in that column a man who had done this before had looked at a single open gap and not trusted it, and had sent a dozen round the back.

Thorn can be cut, girl, said Hesk's voice in her head. *It's only slower.*

"The top!" she screamed. "They've come round the top!" But nobody below could hear her over the water, and she was three terraces from anyone who could. She thought: *the kitchen.*

She went down the terraces the way a sack goes down stairs. She heard her mother before she reached the yard. It wasn't a scream. It was a thin high sound, repeated, like a kettle just before it boils.

Odile was in the kitchen with her back against the oven and the iron kettle held in both hands, and a Northern soldier was filling the doorway. He was big. He had an axe, and one sleeve torn away to the elbow where the thorns had had him, and his face was running with blood. He was in no hurry. Odile was seventy-one years old and had never in her life been so afraid, and it showed: her mouth was open, and she was shaking so hard that the lid rattled against the spout. “Go away,” she was saying. “Go away. Go away.” She said it in the voice she used on hens.

He took a step. She swung the kettle. It was not a good swing. It caught him on the shoulder, and he roared and took her by the wrist, and the kettle hit the flagstones with a sound like a bell.

Widow Pell hit him across the back of the head with a length of stove-wood. Then again. He went down across Odile and did not get up.

Bhelara got there while Pell was still swinging. It took both hands to drag the man off her mother. Odile lay on the floor with her eyes open, looking at the ceiling, and she had picked up the kettle again, or her hand had, and her fingers would not let go of it.

“The bread’s burning,” said Odile, in a voice Bhelara had never heard, very small.

She got up by the oven door. She took the loaves out with her bare hands, one after another, and set them on the table, and did not seem to feel it. Her palms came up white and blistered. She said nothing about them. She stood with her

hands held a little out from her sides, shaking from the shoulders down, and Bhelara, who had never once in her life seen her mother frightened, put her arms around her and held on and found out how small she was.

Across the yard Old Hesk stood in front of the press-house door with a pitchfork in his one hand and a stream of language that had been mostly unprintable since the siege of Corval. He held it against five men. He held it until it took three of them to bring him down, and he took two with him. They saw him fall from the kitchen doorway. Nobody in the kitchen said anything.

The Northerners broke after that. Perhaps it was the water, which had cut their column in two. Perhaps it was the farmers of three parishes, who came up from the lower terraces in a ragged line with hoes and billhooks and one ancient crossbow, which went off, to everyone's surprise, and hit someone. They fell back through the flood, leaving horses and men in the mud, and at the lower gate, in the gray light, somebody threw a torch.

It was a pitch torch thrown by hand, high and slow. The flood had gone down the middle lanes, as water does, and left the east side dry, and the torch landed in the dead grass under the lowest rows. The grass took it. She watched the fire run along the foot of the first terrace and climb into the dry leaves and the lower branches. Citrus wood burns sweet. The smell came up the hill on the dawn wind, heavy and oily and sharp, and she stood in it and thought of a man on his knees in the

dirt with his hands over his ears, and understood for the first time what she had been moving the wind away from.

"The big gate!" she screamed. "Tam! The gate!" It was a stupid thing to scream. The gate had not moved in an hour. But Tam Tolliver, who had been told to stay and pull and had gone on pulling out of pure stubbornness, put his back into it one more time, and a stone she had never known was there ground free of the track, and the gate came up forty minutes late. The water of the whole hillside came down on the east side like a hand and drowned the fire on the fourth row, and the third.

The three rows below were already gone. They burned for an hour while the village stood on the walls and watched, sixty trees that had been there since her grandfather's time, and she did not cry for them. She said "Not this one," very quietly, to the trees above the line, and nothing else burned.

Afterward came a long strange silence made of small sounds. Water dripping. A horse, somewhere, screaming. Someone praying.

They counted. Eleven of the riders were dead in the lanes and the flood. Eleven had fled. Two were never found. Six were taken alive, on their knees in the mud with their hands bound, young men, all of them, with split lips and swollen feet. Of the village, six were dead: Widow Pell's grandson, a man she had known since she was six, two brothers from Ten Wells who had never held anything sharper than a pruning knife, a girl from the next parish whose name she had not learned, and Hesk.

Bhelara walked among the prisoners in the gray light, her hat gone and her braid undone and blood on her sleeve that was not hers, and looked at them. They looked back. One of them, the youngest, a boy of perhaps sixteen with frostbite on his ears and the first fuzz of a beard, spoke in a Verrane so bad she barely understood it.

"Bread," he said. "Please. Bread."

They looked like her brother's letters, she thought. *Cold. Food bad. Home soon.*

She stood there for a very long moment. Then she turned and found her mother, who was already at her elbow with a loaf in her hands, burned black on the bottom, her palms wrapped in wet cloth, as though she had known all along.

"Feed him," Bhelara said.

"I was going to," said Odile. Her voice was still a little small. It was steady.

She watched her mother kneel in the mud and break the bread and put it in the Northern boy's bound hands, a piece at a time, the way you feed a child. He ate as though it were the only thing in the world. Nobody in the lane said a word.

Then the baby kicked, hard, and something low in her gave way. She stood very still. A warm rush went down her legs onto the trampled ground.

"Oh, for pity's sake," said Bhelara, with great dignity.

"About time," said her mother.

PART FIVE

The Bitter Ash and the Sweet Earth

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

The Siege Breaks

The noise came first, before anything he could see.

It had been a bad dawn on the wall. Nine days of thin bread had turned the men to gray wax, the Northern engines had been working on the main gate since midnight, and Valerius had stood through the dark with his hands under his arms, waiting for whatever would finish them. Then, from the east, from the river, a sound came over the roofs that he did not at first understand. A roar. Not a Northern roar; the pitch was wrong. Southern voices. Farm voices, ragged and high, shouting the names of villages.

"The River Gate," said Orme beside him, and his voice cracked. "Majesty. That's the River Gate."

Valerius was already running.

He did not remember giving the order. He remembered the stairs, and the courtyard, and nine hundred half-starved men turning toward him all at once, with faces like people waking from a long sleep. He remembered a horse that someone had saved, a gaunt gray gelding. He remembered pulling on his gloves, one at a time, with fingers that would not quite close, and thinking with great clarity: *he came.*

The River Gate opened. They went through it at a gallop.

The field beyond was a thing he would never describe to anyone. Mud and bodies and broken pikes, and the light coming up gray and thin over all of it. A ring of men, Northerners and his own, breaking up like ice. And at the center of the ring a man in black steel on his knees in the mud, half his face a sheet of blood, holding a dead man in his arms and saying something Valerius could not hear.

He knew those shoulders. He would have known them anywhere.

Alive, thought Valerius, and the thought was so large it blotted out everything else.

Around him the Northern line was dissolving. The white bear had gone down. Without their general the Ninth Banner did not know what to do, and he watched them, wave after wave of ragged men in patched coats, simply stop. Some ran. Some knelt. A great many threw down their swords and sat in the mud with their hands on their heads and did not look up. He rode through them. He had no heart to cut at men who had given up.

That was why he saw the boy.

It was Edrin Wick, the boy he had sent south with a letter, in a gray coat, in the vanguard, alive. He was lying in the mud ten yards away, pinned under a dead horse that had fallen across his legs. He wasn't shouting. He lay there white-faced, hands scrabbling at the saddle, the way a child scrabbles at a door.

There was no decision. There never had been. Valerius was out of the saddle and across the mud with his shoulder under the horse's ribs before he knew he had moved. It was a heavy beast, dead weight, and his arms, which had not truly been strong since he was eleven, shook with it. He heaved. The horse shifted an inch.

I've got you, he heard himself say. It came out of him like something stored for twenty years. *I've got you. Don't move. I've got you.*

The horse moved another inch. Edrin dragged himself clear, sobbing, and lay gasping on the clean mud, and Valerius straightened up, grinning like a fool, with his gloved hands black to the wrist, and thought: *there. That's one.*

Something hit him very hard between the shoulder blades.

It didn't hurt. That was the odd thing. It felt like being shoved by a friend. He took a step forward and looked down and saw the point of a crossbow bolt standing out of his chest, small and bright, with a thread of red running down it. Behind him someone was shouting in the Northern tongue, a high cracked voice, a boy's, saying one word over and over that sounded, for all the world, like *sorry*.

Ah, thought Valerius. He sat down in the mud, quite gently.

It occurred to him, from a long way off, that he had never in his life been able to leave someone under a weight.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

A Kingdom Worth Dying For

He did not remember crossing the field. Afterward Edrin told him he had been screaming at him to stop, and that his legs had somehow already been moving, and that the whole ring of men had opened to let him through like water. Prathen remembered the world coming in red and sideways through his one good eye. A gray horse standing riderless. A crowd making a wide space. And in the middle of the space a man sitting in the mud with an expression of polite inquiry.

"Valerius."

"Ash." The King smiled up at him. It was not the corner-of-the-mouth smile. It was the whole of it, helpless and young. "You look dreadful."

"Don't talk."

"You've lost an eye."

"It was a good fight."

"I'm sure." He coughed. There was red on his lips. Prathen's hands were on him, and the gloves were ruined, gray leather going black, and he knew with a sick certainty what he was looking at, because he had looked at it on a

hundred fields: a bolt through the lung, a bolt that was not coming out.

They carried him into the gatehouse of the River Gate, a small stone guardroom with a table and a bench and a brazier. Orwin the physician came running, gray from the long siege. He looked once at the wound and then at Prathen and said nothing at all, which was the answer.

"Clear the room," said the King, and for the first time in his life Prathen saw Chancellor Orme obey without a word.

Then it was only the two of them and the brazier, and the sounds coming in through the barred window of a city waking up to find itself still alive: a bell, a cheer, a woman laughing from pure relief.

"You came," said Valerius.

"You asked."

"I did. I broke my word."

"You asked so that I could say yes." Prathen's voice was not working properly. "I know what it cost."

"Is the General dead?"

"Yes."

"Did he have children?"

"A daughter. She died."

The King closed his eyes. "Orme says it's hunger. That's what it is, isn't it. Not wickedness. Hunger." He breathed carefully, in small sips. "Tell Isaura to send grain north in the spring. It'll be the most unpopular thing she ever does. That's how she'll know it's right."

"I'll tell her."

“I’ve written it down. In the study. She’ll find it.” His eyes opened again. They were very clear. “What’s in your coat?”

Prathen had nearly forgotten. He took out the linen bundle. It had been crushed against his ribs through a battle, and when he unfolded it the fruit inside was whole, a deep unbruised orange, the largest sun-citrus he had ever seen come off a tree at Windrow.

“She sent it. She said you should taste one that had been in the sun.”

“I’ve eaten nine at one sitting.”

“Not this one.”

He dug his thumbnail in. The oil sprayed, and the smell went through the stone room like a window opening, and the King, who had a bolt in his chest and perhaps an hour to live, breathed it in as though it were the best news he had ever had. Prathen set a segment between his lips.

Valerius chewed. His face did something Prathen had never seen it do. All the held-in lines let go at once.

“Oh,” he said. “That isn’t the same fruit.”

“It’s the same fruit.”

“Then I’ve been eating it wrong for three years.” He started to laugh, and it hurt him, and he stopped, and his eyes were wet. “Tell her I would have come. To be scratched. I’d have liked to be scratched by her thorns.”

“I’ll tell her.”

“Take these off.” He lifted his hands a few inches. “I want you to see them. You never would look.”

“Valerius…”

"Please."

Prathen drew off the gloves, one at a time, as he had watched it done a thousand times and never once helped with. The hands lay in his own: shiny, drawn, the color of old candle wax, the fingers curled halfway. He looked at them. For the first time in twenty years he did not look away.

"They're not so bad," said the King. "People think… They don't even hurt." His fingers closed on Prathen's, as far as they could. "Do you remember what I said in the yard?"

"You said you had me."

"I've had you ever since. That's the trouble. You'll never put it down while there's anything left to hold." He drew a careful breath. "I thought the crown was a weight. Then you went south and showed me what it was for. A wall. A bowl. A woman with a sickle in her hand. I've been guarding that for fifteen years and didn't know it. Thank you for giving me a kingdom worth dying for."

Prathen couldn't speak. He bent his head until his forehead rested on the King's burned hands.

"Give her the gloves. For the thorns." The voice was fainter. "And I called you Ash because I couldn't bear to say the name of a boy who had lost everything. It was a coward's kindness. It's yours. Prathen." He smiled. "Go home, Prathen."

He said nothing more. After a while the hands in Prathen's loosened, gently, and Prathen sat holding them in the small stone room, with the smell of citrus slowly fading under the smell of the brazier, for a very long time.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Long Road South

They buried Valerius on the fourth day, in the crypt beside his father. There was no parade. The city was too tired, and too hungry, and too astonished to still exist. Thirty thousand people stood in the cold streets and watched the coffin go by on a gun carriage, and a great many of them did not know what they were feeling and did not try to name it.

Isaura was seventeen, a thin girl in black with her brother's chin. She wept once at the graveside, very quietly, and after that was entirely composed. She found Prathen afterward in a corridor, standing against the wall in his bandage and his bad coat, trying to be somewhere else.

"He left me a letter," she said. "It says several things. One is that you're to be allowed to go home and never asked for anything again."

"Your Majesty…"

"One is that the south has paid for the north long enough." She was looking at him very steadily. "One is that I'm to send grain."

"He told me."

“It’s a terrible idea. The council will try to have me deposed.” Her mouth twitched at one corner, exactly as her brother’s had. “He said that was how I’d know it was right.”

“He was usually right about the hard ones.”

“You won’t stay?”

“No.”

“He said you wouldn’t.” She held out her hand, and after a moment, awkwardly, he took it. “I’ve been told about the thorns. One day I’m going to come and see them, and I shall be quite alarming about it.”

He rode out of the Southern Gate on the sixth morning with Edrin beside him, because he had been told to bring the boy back, and the gray kid gloves inside his coat, against the pocket where the letters lived, weighing nothing.

Brask was at the gatehouse. He had the armor laid out on a trestle, every plate of it, and he was not pretending he hadn’t been polishing it.

“Let it rust, Brask,” said Prathen.

“Aye, sir.”

“I mean it.”

“Aye, sir. Once a month, sir.”

Prathen did not look back. Behind him, as the gate fell away, he could hear the small steady sound of a rag moving on steel.

They rode south for ten days. The gray went out of the world in the same order it had come in, backward. By the third day the frost was off the ditches. By the sixth the hills had softened. On the eighth Edrin pointed at a green shoot in

a hedge and glanced at him sideways, and Prathen found, to his considerable surprise, that he was laughing.

No word had come north. Every horn on every ridge had been silent since the first night, and he had no way to know what he was riding toward. So for ten days he did not think about it, with great discipline, and thought about nothing else.

On the eleventh morning, at the bend in the cart road below Windrow, the wind changed, and he smelled smoke.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Windrow

Twenty-seven days after he rode out, Bhelara walked the orchard at dawn with her son asleep against her chest.

It was a habit already. Every morning, before Odile was up, she went down through the terraces with the baby in a sling made from an old apron and counted what was left. Two hundred trees standing. Sixty gone. The three lowest rows were black stumps and a smell of old fire that the rain would not wash out. The wall on the fifth terrace lay where she had pulled it down, and would have to be rebuilt stone by stone, which was a job she knew how to do. They had buried Hesk under the highest terrace, beside the wall he had never finished complaining about, and Odile had left a sun-citrus on the grave, which a crow had promptly stolen. Bhelara was not crying. She had done that, for a day and a night, and had found that it did not change the count.

She heard the horses before she saw them. Two. Coming up the cart road slowly, the way tired animals come. She did not turn around. She stood among the burned stumps with her hand on the baby's back and told herself, with great firmness, that it was Gorm. It was a patrol. It was anybody.

The horses stopped at the gate.

* * *

Prathen had known since the bend. The wind had told him: smoke, weeks stale, the smell of citrus wood burned down to its roots, rising from the whole hillside like breath from a sleeping animal. It went into him like a key into a lock. He felt the old world begin to stand up: the roof, the beam, the heat on his cheek.

He got down from Hesk's bay. His legs did not entirely agree. Behind him Edrin said nothing at all, which was the kindest thing anyone had done for him in days.

He walked up through the lower rows. He went through the burned ones first, because there was no other way up: black stumps, ash to his ankles, the smell so thick he could taste it. Every step was a door. Every step, he went through anyway. His right hand was shaking so badly that he took it in his left, and the left was shaking too. He thought: *this is what it costs*. He thought, very clearly: *I am still walking*.

Past the burned rows the trees stood green. He could smell them under the smoke, faint and stubborn and clean. He turned his face toward that.

A woman stood in the third row with her back to him. A small straight figure in her father's straw hat, with a bundle against her chest.

She turned around.

She looked at him. She looked at the bandage across half his face and the empty place beneath it, and the coat that no

longer fit because he had not eaten properly in nine days. Something went across her face too fast to read.

"You're late," said Bhelara.

"I wasn't given a day."

"It's been twenty-seven."

"You counted."

"Someone had to," she said, and her voice broke straight across the middle.

Then he was on his knees in the ash, and so was she, and the baby was between them, small and warm and furious at the disturbance, and they were holding each other as though the ground might be taken away. Neither of them said anything for a long time. He put his forehead against hers and the bandage scraped, and she said "Mind the eye," and he laughed, a rusty, startled noise, and then he was not laughing.

"He ate it," he said, when he could. "The one you sent. I put it in his mouth with my own hand."

"Did he like it?"

"He said it wasn't the same fruit as the crates."

She laughed, and was crying, and pressed the back of her hand to her mouth. "Of course it isn't."

"He said he'd have come. To be scratched."

"He'd have hated it." She was shaking. "He'd have come back every year."

"He gave me something for you." He took the gray gloves from inside his coat. They were stained and ruined and weighed almost nothing. "For the thorns, he said."

She took them in both hands and looked down at them for a long time.

"What's his name?" said Prathen at last. His voice was a wreck. "I couldn't ask. I didn't…"

"I waited." She looked up. "I thought it ought to be you who asked."

"What do you think?"

"I think Ansel." She said it steadily, with her chin up, like a woman putting down a heavy basket she had carried a long way. "He asked me to save him the good bowl. I'm going to."

He nodded. He could not have done anything else.

"You owe me something," said Bhelara. "You said you'd say it when you came back through the door. This isn't the door. But I've got a baby and a burned orchard and a mother who says *eat*, and I'm not waiting any longer."

"I love you," Prathen said. He said it plainly, the way he said everything, as though handing her a tool. "I carried it two hundred miles."

"I know. I could hear it rattling."

They stayed where they were, on their knees in the ash, among the trees that were left. The smoke would be in his head for the rest of his life; he knew that already. It would come for him in the spring with the pruning fires, and in autumn with a certain kind of rain. But there was another smell under it, sharp and clean and stubborn, the one that had been put into his hand in the dirt three years before, and he had learned, at last, which of the two to turn toward.

He turned toward it. The orchard would have to be replanted, row by row, and it would take years. They would do it. That was all, and it was the whole of it. They had survived, and there was a wall on the fifth terrace that still needed mending.

EPILOGUE

The First Dry Evening

The pruning fires were lit on the first dry evening of summer, and Bhelara watched from the top terrace with her son on her hip.

In the burned rows there were new trees now, knee-high, each tied to its stake with a strip of red wool. She had cut Ansel's banner up in the winter, along the old creases, and used it for tying. Red wool held a young graft as well as anything. Odile had watched her do it and said nothing, which was how Bhelara knew it was right.

The Queen's letter had come at midwinter, under a seal the size of her palm. Bhelara read it standing up in the kitchen. No son of the southern provinces was to be levied for

the border unless his province voted it, and the south, the letter added, in a hand that was plainly not a clerk's, had paid for the north long enough. She put it in the bread chest, in the place where the banner had been. It took up less room.

In the same week, in the capital, something happened that nobody there liked. Three hundred wagons of seed grain went north under a white flag at the new Queen's order. The council called it madness. By the thaw there were no more Northern fires in the valley of the Ware, but nobody pretended it was settled. The lords of the valley had buried sons at Ravenspur and lost their barns to the siege, and they did not forgive a Queen for feeding the people who had done it. Two refused to open their granaries. A third had a grain train turned back at the ford by his own riders, and Isaura rode down in black and sat her horse in front of the lead wagon until they let it through, which the carters said was the most frightening thing they had ever seen a girl her age do. Bhelara heard all of it secondhand, from men who had been paid to haul it, and thought about it more than she expected. In Ten Wells they spoke of it the way you speak of an unpopular recipe: it works, so far, but you wouldn't serve it at a wedding. Bhelara thought of it as a winter graft. You could cut clean and bind tight and still lose it to a single hard frost, and the only thing to do was go out every morning and check the binding.

Edrin had come to supper the night they got back and had never left. He had been given Ansel's old bed, and nobody had discussed it. He could graft with either hand now. The

Tolliver twins had refused to fill in their pits, on the grounds that they had been very good pits, and the whole lower lane had to be walked around.

She had worn the King's gloves for the thorn hedge in March. They were far too fine for the work, gray kid never meant to be torn, and they hadn't torn. The first time she put them on, Prathen went into the barn and did not come out for an hour. He didn't do that anymore. He only watched sometimes from the wall, and said nothing, and went on with what he was doing a little more slowly.

* * *

Down at the pit he stood with the long fork. He wore a patch now, plain black leather that Odile had stitched, and the scar beneath it ran from brow to cheek like a seam. He had lit the fire himself. He had asked to. That was something.

She knew the moment before it came. His shoulders changed. The fork went still. Down on the terrace the smoke reached him, drifting across in the dusk, sweet and oily and heavy, and she saw his free hand rise slowly toward his ear.

It had not stopped. It never would. She had stopped waiting for it to, long ago, the way you stop waiting for the rain to quit in a place where it rains.

She was already walking. She put Ansel into her mother's arms at the foot of the terrace without breaking stride, and reached into the pocket of her apron, and by the time she knelt in the dirt in front of him she had the peel half off.

The oil sprayed. The smell came across the little space between them, sharp and cold and clean.

"Chew," said Bhelara.

He chewed. His eyes watered. His hands, one of which was shaking and one of which was not, came down from his ears and found hers.

"Sour," he said.

"First."

"And then…" He swallowed. For a moment she thought he wouldn't finish it. Then something in his face let go, very slightly. "Sweet."

"That's it," she said. "That's the whole trick of it."

Behind her, Odile held the baby up to see the fire. Ansel Valerius, who was seven months old and had a name that Odile said was too much for a person who still drooled, regarded the flames with grave disapproval, and sneezed.

The fire burned down. The smoke thinned and went out over the terraces and the sea, and under it, from the trees that were left and the ones that were coming, the smell of the sun-citrus went on, sharp and clean and quite unimpressed by everything that had happened.

It would be there in the morning.

A Last Word

There is no parade at the end of this book, and that was a choice.

A war story usually finishes at the moment of victory, with the banners up and the music playing. Real endings tend to arrive later and look smaller. They look like a woman walking her terraces at dawn to count what is left. They look like a man learning to sleep through the smell of smoke, and not quite managing it. The king dies, the siege breaks, the army goes home, and somewhere on a high terrace a tree that was planted before any of it began goes on growing toward its first fruit.

The south has a saying that sweet comes after sour. People repeat it as a comfort, which misses the point. It is closer to an instruction. The sour part has to be eaten first, all of it, and nobody gets to skip ahead.

If you finished this book wishing someone had done something differently, you are in good company. Prathen wishes it. So does Valerius. So, in his way, does the general. That is what the story is for.

Would You Still Choose the Orchard?

If I gave you a sword forged from all the battles I've survived, would you teach me that my hands were made for more than holding steel?

If I returned with a thousand scars and a thousand stories of the dead, would you still make room for me at your table?

If the kingdom called my name while the orchard waited for my footsteps, would you understand why, for once, I wished to disappoint a king?

If my hands trembled when I held your cup, but never when I held a blade, would you teach them that gentleness is not another form of weakness?

If I carried the ashes of a thousand homes inside my chest, would you let me build one with you, brick by brick, without asking me to forget the fires?

If the world came marching towards our doorstep, wearing the faces of hungry men and frightened boys, would you still find it in your heart to offer them bread?

If I stood between you and an army, would you know that I was not fighting because I had forgotten how to live, but because I had finally found something worth returning to?

And if the smoke came back, if the flames brought yesterday into tomorrow, if I forgot the warmth of the summer and

remembered only the burning, would you sit beside me until I could breathe again?

Because I have known kings who needed my sword, kingdoms that demanded my blood, and battles that promised glory but returned only names written on folded banners.

I have watched men die for borders they never drew, mothers wait for sons who never came home, and generals carry the last little pieces of a life they could not save.

But then I found you.

You, who never asked me to be a hero.

You, who gave me a tree when I had spent my life guarding thrones.

You, who placed the good bowl before me without ever admitting that you had begun to care.

And now, if every kingdom were to fall, every banner to burn, every sword to rust beneath the rain, would you still take my hand and walk with me through what remains?

For I cannot promise you a life untouched by sorrow. I cannot promise that the ghosts will leave, or that every winter will be kind.

But I can promise you this:

When the fires are over, I will help you plant again.

When the walls collapse, I will learn to build them.

When the harvest comes, I will bring the baskets home.

And when the last light leaves the terraces, I will sit beside you and peel the fruit with my own hands.

For I have spent twenty years learning how to survive the ashes.

And the rest of my life, if you will have me, I would like to spend learning how to live in the sweetness.

So tell me, my love, if the world ever asks me to choose between being its sword and being your home, would you let me choose you?